NO. 149 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 31 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



NINETY-NINE PER CENT FROM 154 CRITICS, AND TWELVE MILLION DOLLARS (P11)

SCREEN & SOUND

LAIKA's best-reviewed film opened third, on a four-thousand-dollar screen average

THE ATELIER

An eleven-thousand-dollar speaker measured worse than a two-thousand-dollar one

THE RABBIT HOLE

Perfumery's six-dollar bottle costs two hundred and eighty to land in Singapore

Source: LAIKA / Fathom Entertainment, from the studio's own release material for *Wildwood*, 15 October 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 149

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THE NUMBER ON THE BOX. It kept turning up. A sensitivity figure wrong by the same amount in the same direction on two different speakers (p6). Three central banks holding the price of money while two of them changed its quantity (p14). A proof of a thirty-year conjecture whose own authors say it "says nothing about solving formulas in practice" (p7). A balance that reads to three decimals and repeats to two (p16). A hazard ratio of sixteen per cent that moves a model by two hundredths (p18). And a litre of petrol with two prices, decided by a chip (p25).

FROM THE DESK

"All models are wrong, but some are useful."

George E. P. Box, *Robustness in the Strategy of Scientific Model Building*, **1979**[1]

A statistician's warning for an issue in which the printed number and the useful number keep turning out to be different quantities (p6).

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.94%	▼ 4bp
US 2-year[2]	4.56%	▼ 5bp
VWRA	$188.54	▼ 1.43%
BNDW	$66.87	▲ 0.17%
S&P 500	7,580.07	▼ 1.82%
Brent[2]	$112.33	▲ 1.38%
Gold	$3,874.40	▼ 3.63%
Bitcoin	$76,627	▼ 1.5%
STI	5,376.74	▼ 0.36%

Gold fell 3.63 per cent on a day its own opportunity cost fell three basis points. That is positioning, not macro (p14). Not advice.[2]

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY

Fifty-two calls came due: 31 right, 15 wrong, 4 pushes, 2 unresolved. Misses first — and one caveat that matters: **seven of the hits are the same Fed call bought seven times across different issues.** On distinct propositions the record is 25–15–4–2.[3]

We set our own high-water mark and drowned in it. No. 129 said gold would close October above **$4,216.30**. That figure was October's *best* close, printed on the 9th. Gold finished at **$3,874.90** — $331 short, including a $146 collapse on the final day.

The hike that got two votes. No. 108 said the Fed would raise in October. It held at 3.75–4.00 on the 28th — but the vote was **10–2** and *both* dissenters wanted precisely our quarter-point. Wrong by two votes out of twelve.

Two basis points. No. 120 said 2s10s would be wider than 40bp at end-October. On the 30th: 4.94 less 4.56 = **38bp**. Right about the steepening all month; wrong on the one day we were graded.

Coyote won. No. 87 called it a symbolic win under $45m domestic. It finished on **$60,101,763** at home and $101.6m worldwide.

We said there was no Singapore price. There is one. No. 120 said the Nothing Headphone (1) Pro still had none on 31 October. Its own Singapore store lists it at **S$549**.

And the surprise hit. No. 109 said Mecklenburg-Vorpommern's certified result would leave the CDU under five per cent with no seats. Final: **4.9 per cent, nought of 71**.

The haze broke exactly as called. No. 135 said all five regions would hold a full day under 100. They did, on **26 October**, worst reading 96 — eight days after a peak of 230.

SOURCES 1 George E. P. Box, "Robustness in the Strategy of Scientific Model Building", in *Robustness in Statistics*, Academic Press, 1979. 2 Levels at Friday 30 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the United States Treasury's own daily curve supplies both yields. **Bitcoin is a level at 21:20 UTC, not a close; the equity index, the fund price and the Straits Times Index are each single-sourced because the exchanges' own pages refused this desk.** 3 Every claim in this magazine's own predictions ledger whose check-by date had passed was graded against a figure read where it is published: a central bank's own statement and implementation note; the Treasury's own curve files; an electoral commission's certified count; a national environment agency's own air-quality interface; exchange and market-data histories; a maker's own store listing; a code repository's own merge record; and a box-office tracker's title page.

THE WORLD · THE BINANCE THEFT

Hackers drain $6.3bn from Binance hot wallets in about twenty minutes

The exchange blames a compromised DevOps engineer's laptop, has set aside more than $6.34bn of company funds, and says withdrawals restart in phases within about 34 hours.

Binance's hot wallets were drained across ten blockchains on the evening of **29 October 2026**, beginning about **20:05 UTC** and running roughly **twenty minutes**. In its own statements of **30 October** the exchange put the loss at **US$6.3bn** — the largest crypto theft recorded, about four times the US$1.5bn Bybit record of February 2025 — and attributed the breach to "a compromised DevOps engineer's laptop" that let an attacker reach a service container and submit unauthorised withdrawals.[1]

Binance says it will cover it. Its first update promised that "Binance will cover all losses from the SAFU fund and the company's funds"; its second, twelve hours later, disclosed "additional points of breach" and said it had **set aside more than US$6.34bn**, of which about **US$5bn** is already in the stolen token types — roughly **80 per cent cover**, with the remainder being bought on the market and over the counter. About **US$3bn** has been frozen on-chain. Withdrawals restart in phases in about **34 hours**, and a proof-of-reserves result is promised for **2 November**.[1]

Attribution points at Pyongyang, and is not yet official. Blockchain-analysis firms have named the North Korean unit tracked as TraderTraitor; **no government or law-enforcement agency has attributed the theft**, Binance has named no culprit, and the exchange has published no root cause.[2]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Frames it as a weapons-programme story rather than a fintech one, citing TRM's **Ari Redbord** calling it **"a global security issue, not just a crypto theft"**, and setting it against South Korean intelligence's estimate of about US$1.1bn stolen across five years. It notes Pyongyang denies hacking and that the attribution is the analysis firms' conclusion, not a state's.[2]

NEW YORK — CNBC

Frames it as a credibility contest. Hours after the breach, Elon Musk trolled the exchange; founder **Changpeng Zhao** replied on X: **"Elon, have a lot of respect for you, but bad time to troll. Please stop."** **Beijing's own business press carried nothing at all** — this magazine read the Global Times business index in full for both 29 and 30 October and found no item on the largest theft in history.[3]

THE CHATTER · SCHRÖDINGER'S ASSETS

From the Hacker News thread, 279 points. **Aboutplants** on solvency: "They have it, as long as no one tries to withdraw it." **booi** named it: "Schrodingers assets." **ActionHank** on the run risk: "anyone who had their crypto there will move elsewhere, then Binance has -12b." **FitchApps**, on the control that failed: "No devops/sys admin should have access to live wallets with real funds." **verteu**, on the vector: "You can buy a lot of 0days when your budget is billions."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · EVEN THE NUMBER IS CONTESTED

Mark Karpeles, who ran Mt Gox, told Reuters the attackers probably accessed the private keys of at least two wallets — which directly contradicts Binance's claim to have found no evidence of a key leak. **Elliptic's Tom Robinson** cautions that attribution **"is not yet certain"**. And the headline figure is unsettled across a **17 per cent spread**: one analysis firm published **US$5.5bn**, Binance says **6.3**, TRM **6.36**, Elliptic **6.43**. **The falsification test is dated:** if the proof-of-reserves snapshot lands clean on 2 November and withdrawals reopen on time, the solvency sceptics are wrong; if either slips, they are right.[5]

About 80%

THE SHARE OF THE LOSS BINANCE ALREADY HOLDS IN THE STOLEN TOKEN TYPES. THE REST IT IS BUYING ON THE MARKET — WHICH IS A PROMISE TO COVER, NOT A COVER[1]

SOURCES 1 Binance's own Security Incident Updates, published 30 October 2026 at 02:23 and 19:33 and read at source, including the quoted commitments and the timings. 2 Al Jazeera, 30 October 2026; Elliptic's own statement on attribution. 3 CNBC, 30 October 2026; the Global Times business index for 29 and 30 October, read in full by this desk. 4 Hacker News item 50303172, usernames as posted. 5 Karpeles via Reuters as carried by Al Jazeera; the competing loss figures as published by each firm. **Reddit refused this desk, so the circulating technical claim about delegation signatures three minutes before the drain is noted as chatter and not printed as fact; nor is the speculation linking the timing to a separate supply-chain incident, which other commenters in the same thread disputed.**

THE WORLD · TOLEDO AND TAI PO

Pedro Sánchez says Spain's confidence in high-speed rail is broken

A Renfe AVE struck a stationary Iryo train near Urda on 28 October, killing about 69 — seventeen minutes after a signalling failure stopped six trains.

At **08:53 on 28 October 2026**, Renfe's AVE 2080 ran into the rear of a stationary Iryo service near Urda, Toledo. About **69 people** were killed; **397** were aboard the AVE and **147** the Iryo. After an emergency meeting on **30 October**, Prime Minister **Pedro Sánchez** said: **"hay una confianza quebrada en el sistema de alta velocidad en nuestro país"** — a broken confidence in our country's high-speed system. It is the second such crash in a year.[1]

The seventeen minutes before it are reconstructed from recordings. At **08:30** an IT failure disabled the line's signalling safety system across about **63km**, halting six trains. At **08:36** a controller at Madrid's Atocha centre authorised AVE 2080 to resume **at normal line speed** under lineside block, confirming it when the driver queried the instruction. At **08:48** the Iryo driver reported she could not restart the system and was stationary — and the AVE, by then running for some **25km**, was not told to stop. The transport minister called the control centre's decision **"inexplicable"**.[1]

In Hong Kong, Secretary for Housing **Winnie Ho** resigned on **28 October** and Chief Executive **John Lee** accepted it the next day, bowing in public apology with seven other officials after an independent committee found four government bodies had failed in their oversight of the Wang Fuk Court renovation. The fire of **26 November 2025** killed **168** people and affected **1,984** households. Lee said Ho "should bear political responsibility" though no personal wrongdoing was found: **"As the chief executive, I apologize to the disaster victims and the public."**[2]

> *"She was not being sacked. She resigned herself."*

The committee faulted the Housing Bureau's Independent Checking Unit most heavily, for not investigating complaints about foam boards and non-fire-retardant scaffolding nets; the consultant and main contractor had **"cut corners"**, with many signs of bid-rigging on a contract worth more than **HK$300m**. Seven people and two companies have been charged. The checking unit will be replaced in November, and legislation to criminalise bid-rigging in maintenance contracts is among seven promised reforms. The bereaved are not satisfied: **Phyllis Lo**, who lost her mother, said of the resignation, "She was not being sacked. She resigned herself."[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE HORMUZ FILE DID THIS WEEK

The strait stayed shut to routine traffic and two things moved. Oman's maritime security centre evacuated **25 crew** from the burning Panama-flagged tanker *RITI*, which it said had been targeted; the Revolutionary Guard claimed a supertanker carrying **two million barrels** had been stopped by a naval mine on an "unauthorised route". Against that, the American regional commander said his forces had cleared Iranian mines from the primary transit lanes and that Iran is now exporting no oil at all. Transits remain in **single digits a day** against a normal hundred-plus (p14).[3]

THE SCEPTIC · NUMBERS THIS DESK WILL NOT PRINT

The Spanish death toll is not settled and no official figure exists. One outlet says "at least 69" while carrying 74 in its own link; another ran 68; a by-train split sums to 68. **The prime minister's office publishes no casualty count in any of its three statements, and the transport ministry refused this desk outright.** So this page says "about 69" and names the source rather than inventing precision. Separately, Israel's final election count is reported to have left Benjamin Netanyahu's bloc short of a majority with Arab-led parties at an unprecedented total, and the police found no evidence for Likud's claim that the vote was stolen — **but this desk could not open the elections committee's own results page, so it prints no seat numbers at all.**[4]

SOURCES 1 The Spanish prime minister's office, statements of 28, 29 and 30 October 2026, read at source for the quotation and the emergency status; the minute-by-minute reconstruction and the minister's "inexplicable" from Euronews, 29 October, read in full. 2 Associated Press wire copy of 29 October 2026, read at source, for the resignation, the committee's findings and both quotations; **Hong Kong government sites served empty content to this desk, so no primary document was read and the committee's own report is not cited here.** 3 Agency copy of 30 October 2026 on the Omani evacuation, the Guard's claim and the American commander's statement. 4 The conflicting tolls as published by four outlets; **the Spanish transport ministry returned HTTP 403 and the Israeli elections committee's own page could not be opened.**

SINGAPORE · A RECORD INSIDE A FALLING INDEX

A five-room flat at SkyParc @ Dawson sold for S$1.818m, the first above S$1.8m

It is 1,195 square feet at S$1,522 per foot on the fortieth floor — in a quarter when the resale price index fell 0.1 per cent for the third time running.

A five-room flat on the fortieth storey of Block 96 Dawson Road, in the **SkyParc @ Dawson** development in Queenstown, sold in October for **S$1,818,000** — the first Housing Board resale flat to cross S$1.8m. It runs to **1,195 square feet**, about **S$1,522 a square foot**, with roughly **94 years** left on a lease that began in 2021. It beats the previous national record, set in April at City Vue @ Henderson, by **5.2 per cent**.[1]

The context makes it a story rather than a brag. It sits **S$588,000 above Queenstown's twelve-month median** of S$1.23m. Meanwhile the index around it goes the other way: the resale price index **fell 0.1 per cent in the third quarter, a third consecutive decline**, while transactions **rose 19.5 per cent** to 7,645.[1]

Four agencies made a change that lands closer to most households. From **30 October**, loans on **individually owned private-hire cars** are capped at the same levels as private cars: a maximum **70 per cent** of an open market value at or below S$20,000, **60 per cent** above it, with a maximum tenure of **seven years** and the purchase price including taxes and the certificate of entitlement. The trigger was a surge of roughly **500 individually owned self-drive registrations a month**, with the ministries saying some buyers used the exemption **with no intention of providing any service**. A separate entitlement category for hire and leasing firms was considered and rejected, on the ground that it would raise rentals and fares.[2]

A record price printed inside a falling index.

The haze file moved too, and this is the genuine delta. On **30 October** the law ministry and the environment agency named a **seven-member Panel of Assessors** — three investigations firms and four legal appointments, among them **Toby Landau KC** — to assess the **ten** companies served notices a week earlier, with a government-appointed adviser coordinating. The assessments will be conducted **at the companies' own expense**, companies are "expected to cooperate fully", and the government intends to table amendments to the transboundary haze legislation **at the next parliamentary sitting**. Some law firms were passed over because they already act for the companies identified.[3]

THE CHATTER · TWO LABOUR NUMBERS, ONE MORNING

The manpower ministry published its third-quarter advance release on **30 October** carrying both halves of the argument. Employment grew **27,700**, up from 11,400 in the second quarter. And retrenchments rose to **4,800** from 4,620 — **the highest quarterly figure since late 2020** — with resident unemployment ticking to **3.0 per cent** and citizen unemployment to **3.1**. The ministry's own language carries the tension: the market "continued to expand… with stronger employment growth", and separately shows what it calls weaknesses "that should be monitored". Business reorganisation remains the main driver.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · AN ACCUSATION WITHOUT EVIDENCE

Indonesia's energy minister **Bahlil Lahadalia** alleged on **28–29 October** that "not all of the 148 cargoes we send are used for Singapore's own needs, but some are traded", and told Singapore not to "teach Indonesia on how to honour contracts". He offered no evidence. Singapore's energy and trade ministry replied on the 30th that the piped gas **"is for domestic use, and not for export"**, and that liquefied cargo "usually moves from source to destination country directly" without physically passing through Singapore. The scale: the cut is under **2 per cent** of daily demand, in a country drawing **about 95 per cent** of its electricity from imported gas. **The energy authority's own pages returned empty to this desk, so those percentages are read through two outlets rather than at the regulator.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Two property titles' reporting of 30 October 2026, read at source, including the per-foot and median comparisons; **the Housing Board publishes no individual transaction release, so the record itself is press-sourced, and two accounts disagree on the storey — this page prints the one internally consistent with a 43-storey block**. The quarterly index and transaction figures from the board's own third-quarter data of 23 October. 2 The law ministry's own release, read at source, with the joint statement confirmed in the business press. 3 The law ministry and environment agency's joint release of 30 October, read at source; **the release itself declines to name or number the companies, and the list circulating in the press is not reproduced here**. 4 The manpower ministry's own Labour Market Advance Release for the third quarter, 30 October 2026, read at source. 5 Both ministers' statements as carried on 30 October; **the energy authority's own media pages returned empty content or a 404**. 6 Reported 30 October; the article itself was not opened.

THE ATELIER · BOOKSHELF LOUDSPEAKERS

A $2,250 Buchardt outscores an $11,000 Børresen on the same Klippel rig

Erin Hardison measured both: preference 5.38 against 2.38, flatness ±1.6dB against ±5.1dB — and Dutch & Dutch raises its prices tomorrow, 1 November.

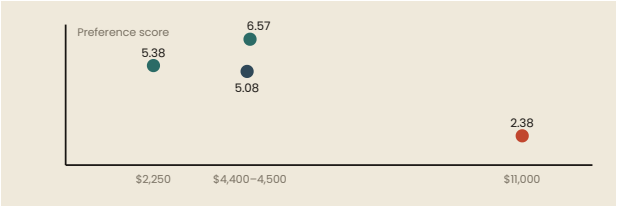
The standmount loudspeaker is the one hi-fi object whose quality can now be read off a public number. The **Klippel Near-Field Scanner** produces anechoic-equivalent data in an ordinary room; the CEA/CTA-2034 "Spinorama" turns it into the Harman–Olive preference score.[1]

Three pairs tell the story. **Buchardt's S400 MKII**, about **US$2,250**, scores **5.38**; **Revel's M126Be**, about **$4,400**, **5.08**; **Børresen's X3**, about **$11,000**, **2.38** — Hardison finding a "notable hole in the mid-range frequencies".[2]

What separates the tiers is the motor, not the badge. Woofer distortion comes largely from the surround changing the effective radiating area as the cone moves, and from the force factor varying with excursion. **Purifi** attacks that geometry and publishes the result: second and third harmonics about **−60 and −70dB**, intermodulation near **−50dB**.[3] **ATC** hand-winds a flat-wire coil into a **9kg** motor and rates its SCM19 at **108dB** — from a 150mm driver.[4]

Who cuts their own cones is a short list: ATC, ProAc, Harbeth, KEF and Dynaudio. **Buchardt buys in and says so**, naming an SB Acoustics woofer on its own page.[5] The prestige names are themselves owned. **Scan-Speak** calls itself "an independent company within the **Eastech Group**". **Dynaudio is 83 per cent owned by GoerTek**, the Shenzhen ODM — and has kept its drivers in Skanderborg for twelve years, the honest counter to the cynical version.[6]

For a Singapore buyer the cabinet outranks the badge. Buchardt specifies **15mm moisture-proof fibreboard**; almost nobody else states a board grade. Falcon's LS3/5a is "graded Baltic Ply with Beech fillets" — cross-laminated, and steadier in humidity than MDF. The 1976 specification happens to suit the tropics.[7]



Measured preference against price. A *Meridian* original, plotted from the published Klippel data recomputed at spinorama.org.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS HERE ACTUALLY DO

On StereoNET's Singapore thread, **naglfar** reported mould on his speakers before running a dehumidifier around the clock, emptying "about 1+ liter of water" every two or three days. **pigscanfly** gave the number: "The ideal RH is 45% to 55%" — warning that below 40% "is not good for rubber and wood materials as it will dry up and crack". The failure runs both ways.[8]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE BADGE IS DEFENDING

The spec sheet is optimistic in one direction only. Buchardt claims **87dB** and measures **84.7**; Børresen claims **88** and measures **85.9** — both about **2.3dB** out, roughly a doubling of the amplifier you need. Finish is priced like a component and changes none: ATC's SCM20PSL runs **£3,990** standard and **£5,645** with high gloss.[9] And the strongest argument against the category: a correct subwoofer lifts that $2,250 Buchardt from **5.38 to 7.46**, higher than any passive speaker here reaches unaided, at any price.[2]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Neckties — who weaves the silk in Como, Macclesfield and Kyoto, and whose name goes on it.

Mortar and pestle — Thai granite, Mexican basalt or a ridged suribachi: which stone grinds and which leaches.

Rules, squares & calipers — the tools that decide whether a cut is true, from makers who never advertise.

SOURCES 1 spinorama.org's own methodology and reviewer list, read at source. 2 Erin's Audio Corner measurement pages for the Børresen X3, Buchardt S400 MKII and Revel M126Be, with scores recomputed by spinorama.org from the published Klippel data. 3 Purifi Audio's own USHINDI transducer pages. 4 ATC's own SCM19 page and its July 2024 hi-fi price list (the most recent published list located; confirm current). 5 Buchardt's own S400 MK3 product page; ProAc's and Harbeth's own sites. 6 Scan-Speak's own About page; AudioXpress's report of the GoerTek acquisition, October 2014. 7 Buchardt's own spec sheet; Falcon Acoustics' own LS3/5a pages. 8 StereoNET Singapore dehumidifier thread, posts dated 28–30 April 2009 — **old, and the only local owner evidence of this kind that could be read**. 9 ATC's own price list, as above. 10 Falcon Acoustics' component shop; Salk Sound's own notice. **Audiogon, Stereophile, diyAudio and hifishark refused this desk: no resale evidence here, and no quotation from any of them.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE EXPONENTIAL TIME HYPOTHESIS

OpenAI claims a proof that the Exponential Time Hypothesis is false

Anthropic published its own Lean-checked refutation on 27 October, credited to Claude — and five days on, the public record of independent checking is that an unnamed few got the files to compile.

OpenAI published a preprint dated **25 October 2026** and a Lean formalisation the next day claiming that the **Exponential Time Hypothesis** is false — that for every fixed k, satisfiability of a k-CNF formula can be decided, and its solutions counted, in time subexponential in the number of variables.[1] Two days later **Anthropic** posted its own refutation, "A $2^{o(n)}$ Time Algorithm for 3-SAT", crediting the core algorithm to an internal Claude research model that found it on **16 October** across **14 million output tokens** with no human input, formalised in **1,050 Lean modules**.[2]

Lance Fortnow, who has written the field's best-known complexity blog for two decades, gave his assessment on **28 October**: "I have not verified the proof myself, but it is safe to assume now that the exponential-time hypothesis is toast." He added the limits in the same post. The algorithm "applies to k-SAT but not to NP problems in general"; it "gives nothing new for Subset Sum or Traveling Salesman", because the reductions blow up the variable count; and the failure of the hypothesis does not falsify the many hardness results derived from it, which remain conditional statements.[3]

What the machines proved is narrower than the headline. OpenAI's own repository calls its manuscripts "best understood as a form of raw research data, rather than polished academic papers", says about **42 per cent** of top-line results are formalised, and records roughly **three hours** of thinking compute per result across some **4,000** problems.[1] Anthropic's own README is blunter still: "The result is purely asymptotic and says nothing about solving formulas in practice."[2]

> *"This represents a bit of a new practice for TCS."*

Russell Impagliazzo, Mohan Paturi and Ryan Williams — two of whom gave the hypothesis its name — stood up a public examination site, and its opening post says their involvement "should not be taken as certification of the claim". On **30 October**, **Francis Zane** posted what the verification actually amounts to so far: "a few people have reached out" who "run the Lean proofs locally and confirmed that they compiled". No names, no hardware, no build times, and no statement of what was not checked.[4]

PITTSBURGH — CARNEGIE MELLON

Ryan O'Donnell published a six-page exposition on 29 October, taking the sparse-permanent route and reaching $2^{O(n(\log\log n)^2/\sqrt{\log n})}$. Its footnote: "Produced by odonnell@cs.cmu.edu through interaction with LLMs." The human explanation of the machine's proof was itself machine-assisted.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE OTHER NUMBER THIS WEEK

Amazon reported third-quarter results on **29 October** carrying **$77.3bn** of purchases of property and equipment in the quarter — against Alphabet's $51.4bn and Microsoft's $39.4bn (p14). Nine-month capital spending reached **$175.7bn**; trailing free cash flow is an **outflow of $42.4bn**, against a $14.8bn inflow a year earlier.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO SUMS THAT DO NOT CLOSE

Amazon's net income **fell** to **$20.7bn** from $21.2bn while operating income rose $10.7bn, because the comparable quarter carried **$9.5bn** of pre-tax Anthropic investment gains: the operating business grew and the bottom line shrank. And **$175.7bn** of nine-month capital spending against a roughly **$220bn** full-year guide implies about **$44bn** in the fourth quarter — a sequential fall of **43 per cent**. Neither the release nor the 10-Q reconciles it. **This arithmetic is this magazine's own.**[6]

SOURCES 1 The openai/math repository and its preprint directory, read at source; OpenAI's own announcement page returned HTTP 403 to this desk, so all OpenAI framing here comes from its repository. 2 The anthropics/formal-math repository README, read raw at source. 3 Lance Fortnow, "The Exponential Time Refutation", *Computational Complexity*, 28 October 2026, updated 29 October. 4 ethdiscussion.blog, the examination site's kickoff post of 26 October and Francis Zane's "Lean Replications" of 30 October. 5 O'Donnell's exposition, dated 29 October, extracted from the PDF at cs.cmu.edu. 6 Amazon's own third-quarter release of 29 October and its Form 10-Q filed 30 October, accession 0001018724-26-000040, confirmed on EDGAR. 7 EDGAR company search, CIK 0002130357, checked 30 October; the rating via The Edge's syndication of Bloomberg, 27 October. **A reported claim that Anthropic's paper concedes its bound beats exhaustive search only past $10^{10,000}$ variables is held: it could not be read in the paper itself.**

THE HOME LAB · A TWO-GIGABYTE SHORTCUT

Unsloth's 2.25GB draft model doubles decode speed on a 233GB Mistral build

The full quant ladder for Mistral-Large-4-1T-A52B published from 29 October runs from 233GB to a 2.1TB BF16 — and the repository totals 7.6 terabytes.

Unsloth published the complete dynamic-quant ladder for **Mistral-Large-4-1T-A52B** from **29 October**, and the number this magazine has carried for three issues holds: the smallest build, **UD-IQ1_S, is 233GB** across six shards. Read folder by folder rather than off the card, the ladder runs IQ1_M **260GB**, IQ2_XXS **302**, Q2_K_XL **378**, IQ3_XXS **424**, Q3_K_XL **493**, Q4_K_XL **605**, Q5_K_XL **784**, Q6_K_XL **890**, Q8_0 **1.12TB** and BF16 **2.1TB**. The repository totals **7.6TB**.[1]

The actionable item is far smaller than any of them. A speculative draft model, **DSPARK**, ships in the same repository at **2.25GB** in Q8_0 and 4.21GB in BF16. Run with a maximum of three draft tokens, Unsloth reports a mean acceptance length of about **2.5** and roughly **double the decode speed at batch size one**. A 2.25-gigabyte file doubles the throughput of a 233-gigabyte model.[1]

The hardware guidance at source is plain: one-bit wants a machine with **256GB** of memory, two-bit roughly **384–512GB**, and the near-full-precision Q8 build **1.2TB and up**. The architecture is about a trillion parameters total with roughly **49B active per token**, **128 routed experts** of which four are active plus one shared, and a one-million-token context. Vision needs a separate 3.44GB projector.[1]

> *"I think I need about a terabyte more RAM, to run that."*

Nobody agrees on the four-bit figure to within twenty-five gigabytes. The community says 610GB; Unsloth's own Q4_K_XL folder sums to **605GB**; ggml-org's NVFP4 build, verified shard by shard, comes to **630GB**. That spread is the honest state of the art for a model released a fortnight ago.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE BUILDERS SAID

From the Hacker News thread of 29 October, 1,664 points and 433 comments. **prophesi**: "The lowest quant will still require 256GB VRAM to run inferences." **jacquesm** described the machine he uses — "a $25k custom build with 8 video cards" — and noted the price "was only valid for early 2026", advising the memory-poor instead to "try a 3 to 5B active MOE model, use the rest as cache to stream weights from NVMe". **dlcarrier**, more briefly: "I think I need about a terabyte more RAM, to run that."[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE INDEX AND THE QUANT

Mistral's headline **26** on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index comes from a benchmark rebuilt four weeks ago. **Nathan Lambert** wrote on **28 October** that "Artificial Analysis's business model is to make money from the labs to verify their results", and on its shift to private tests: "you're putting complete trust in the private benchmark builder". He also concedes the other way — "I do think the previous index was flattering the open weight models too strongly". On the quants themselves, **dunefox**: "IME excessively quantised models are almost unusable," reporting better results from smaller unquantised models.[3]

122 days

VLLM PULL REQUEST 47123, OPENED 30 JUNE, STILL OPEN AND NOT A DRAFT — WITH AN INDEPENDENT REPRODUCTION POSTED ON 24 SEPTEMBER CONFIRMING IT FIXES THE BUG[4]

STILL ON THE SHELF

vLLM issue 55766 — still open, no assignee, no labels, no maintainer comment. A new report on **24 October** reproduces the NaN logits on v0.32.0 only with the older model runner, and points at the same uniform-decode check.[4]

No tokens-per-second figure for any Mistral Large 4 quant on consumer hardware exists at any readable source — third issue running. Perplexity numbers appear only inside chart images.

SOURCES 1 The Unsloth Mistral-Large-4-1T-A52B-GGUF repository on Hugging Face — model card, raw README and the file listings of the IQ1_S and Q2_K_XL folders, each read directly rather than taken from the card; ggml-org's NVFP4 repository for the 630GB figure, counted shard by shard. 2 Hacker News item 50289418, 29 October 2026, usernames as posted. 3 Nathan Lambert, *Interconnects*, 28 October 2026; the quantisation comment from the same Hacker News thread. 4 The vLLM repository on GitHub: pull request 47123 and issue 55766, both read at source on 30 October. **Reddit refused this desk again, so there is no r/LocalLLaMA sentiment anywhere on this page; every community line above is Hacker News or a project's own tracker, attributed by username.**

THE KIT · THE PRICE NOBODY GUESSED

Nikon prices the NIKKOR Z 120-300mm f/2.8 at $13,999.95

The lens ships in mid-November at 2,735g, 515g lighter than the F-mount version it replaces, with a 1.4× teleconverter built in on a switch.

Nikon announced and priced the **NIKKOR Z 120-300mm f/2.8 TC VR S** on **29 October 2026** at **US$13,999.95**, shipping from **mid-November**. The rumour mill had run at about **$8,000** since the development announcement in May. The published number is **75 per cent higher**.[1]

What it buys is a built-in **1.4× teleconverter** that takes the lens to **420mm at f/4** on a single switch, internal focus and internal zoom so the barrel never changes length, and **6.5 stops** of stabilisation on Nikon's 2024 CIPA measurement at the telephoto end without the converter. At **2,735g** it is **515g** lighter than the F-mount lens it succeeds. Nikon calls it "the world's first" constant-f/2.8 zoom with a 1.4× converter inside.[1]

Apple unveiled the **24-inch iMac with M6** on **27 October** at **US$1,499** and **$1,699**, pre-orders from 28 October and on sale **6 November**. Its headline claim is an odd one for an all-in-one: up to **12× faster on-device AI prompt processing in LM Studio** than the M1 iMac, and up to **5×** the M4. Apple is quoting a local-inference app on an iMac page.[2]

"The lens is surprisingly nimble."

Formlabs opened orders for the **Form Studio 1**, its first sub-$700 resin printer, shipping globally from **16 November** at **US$699**. The build volume is 5.9 litres at a 35-micron pixel; peak speed is 130mm an hour, averaging 40 at a 100-micron layer.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT $699 DOES NOT BUY

Read off Formlabs' own store, the printer is the smaller half of the bill. The Wash+Cure station is **$199**, a build platform **$65**, a resin tank **$55**, resin **from $29 a litre** — about **$1,018** before a first usable print, and the machine **has no built-in air filter**. The UL Greenguard Gold certification the coverage leads on is conditional on running the maker's own resins *and* a VOC extractor that is not in the price. Below it sits an Elegoo Mars 5 Ultra at $269–338; above it, Formlabs' own Form 4 at $2,625.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR SPECIFICATIONS MISSING

Nikon's release omits the element and group count, the minimum focus distance, the filter size and the length — four things a buyer needs — and **no independent review, MTF chart or measurement exists yet**. On the iMac, the **12×** figure is prompt processing, not decode tokens per second, and its footnote describes a September 2026 test whose baseline is not fully specified; the "world's fastest single-threaded CPU" claim names no comparator. At **170GB/s** and a **24GB** maximum, this machine is nowhere near the 256GB the model on the facing page wants (p8). **That last comparison is this desk's own.**[1][2]

S$2,099

THE REPORTED SINGAPORE PRICE OF THE TEN-CORE IMAC — SINGLE-SOURCED TO ONE LOCAL OUTLET. APPLE'S OWN SINGAPORE STORE LISTS ALL SEVENTEEN CONFIGURATIONS AND "AVAILABLE STARTING 6TH NOVEMBER", BUT SERVES NO PRICES AT ALL[2]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Audio-Technica ATH-AWX7000 — a fourth issue, and the answer is still nothing. A search restricted to Audio Science Review, RTINGS and Head-Fi returns **zero** results for the model; every hit is the open-back ADX7000. Retailer listings now circulate 5Hz–50kHz, 97dB/mW and 48Ω, but **the maker's own page returned HTTP 403**, so those figures are unconfirmed. **This desk now retires the measurement peg.**

Samsung Galaxy Buds On — still no Singapore price, checked 30 October. KRW 299,000 remains the only published figure, and the IP54 rating two outlets printed is still not Samsung's.

SOURCES 1 Nikon's own press-room page for the NIKKOR Z 120-300mm f/2.8 TC VR S, 29 October 2026, read at source; second source DPReview, same day. 2 Apple's own newsroom release of 27 October and its Singapore store listing, both read at source — the Singapore prices are single-sourced to TechCoffeehouse, 27 October, which also puts Singapore pre-orders a day after the United States; Apple's Singapore pages publish no prices. Second source MacRumors, 27 October. 3 Formlabs' own Form Studio 1 product and store pages, read at source. **The two review verdicts in circulation were not read: one outlet returned HTTP 403 and the other served truncated content, so the review peg is reported as unconfirmed. The VOC extractor's $179 price is secondary — it does not appear on Formlabs' own accessories page.**

THE GOOD LIFE · TWO MOVEMENTS, ONE WATCH

Louis Erard and Vianney Halter launch the Futur Antérieur at CHF 4,950

The riveted twin portholes run on two separate Sellita movements — one for the hours, one for the seconds — in 178 pieces per dial, announced 30 October.

Louis Erard and **Vianney Halter** launched the **Futur Antérieur** on **30 October 2026** at **CHF 4,950** before taxes, in **178 pieces** per dial colour and 78 duo sets at CHF 9,900. The case is 38mm by 8.85mm in steel; the design is lifted from Halter's **Antiqua** perpetual calendar of 1998, the watch that invented his retro-futurism and gave this one its name — the French future-perfect tense.[1]

Its oddity is mechanical. Two stepped sub-dials sit behind riveted bezels, and each is driven by **its own Sellita SW100 automatic**: one keeps hours and minutes, the other runs the seconds. They are not linked. **Daryll Ng**, writing from Singapore the same day, put the objection plainly: "We are a bit deflated by this — it means that the seconds simply tick without any reference to the hour and minute hands." He still called CHF 4,950 "great value for something which so strongly showcases Vianney Halter's design language".[1]

There is no Singapore price, and the maker's own store serves Singapore in Swiss francs. There is also a date problem worth knowing before anyone reaches for a card: the trade press reported the watch as available immediately, while **Louis Erard's own homepage says "Available November 5 at 10 AM CET"** and the duo-set page offers a waiting list rather than a basket.[2]

> ***"The dials copy the Antiqua's look but not its hand-finished technique."***

Further up, **Armin Strom** priced its **Minute Repeater Resonance 12:59** at **CHF 390,000** on **26 October**, in 25 pieces. Its trick is a demonstration mode that chimes 12:59 on command whatever the time, and its resonance clutch tolerates up to **250 seconds a day** of rate difference between the two balances, against roughly five for an inertial system.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE TRADE READS THE DIAL

JX Su of SJX, 30 October, on the same watch: the twin-movement layout "seems illogical", and the dials "copy the Antiqua's look but not its hand-finished technique" — the original's was engraving filled with lacquer. He rates the finishing "impressive for the price" and would have preferred a case without branding. Ng prefers the silver dial, because the gilt rivets "pop a bit more".[1]

THE SCEPTIC · A PRICE WITHHELD, AND A FACTORY CUT

A. Lange & Söhne's **Datograph Perpetual**, announced 24 October in 50 pieces, is still **"price on request"** — the fifth issue running this desk has reported no figure. The one new fact is a mechanism: Deployant reports that **Sincere Fine Watches manages South-East Asian distribution** and that its "retail quotations reflect precious metal premiums upon delivery". SJX calls the watch's **36-hour reserve** "short for a perpetual calendar". Meanwhile **Zenith cut about 200 jobs on 24 October** — roughly 100 at Le Locle, about half that site's workforce — its chief executive blaming the strong franc, American tariffs and weak Middle East and Asian demand.[4]

US$36,700

WHAT LOT 208 AT PHILLIPS' GENEVA SALE ON 7–8 NOVEMBER — A SQUARE YELLOW-GOLD ROLEX REF. 3830 — LAST SOLD FOR IN 2004. ITS ESTIMATE NOW IS ABOVE CHF 1 MILLION[5]

IN BRIEF

Luxman announced the P-800u headphone amplifier on 23 October at ¥550,000, for a November release: four channels fully balanced, 8W a side into 16Ω, 15.7kg. **Luxman's own press page returned HTTP 403 to this desk**, so every figure here is read at the Japanese trade title Phile-web. No overseas price.

Hilton opened the Waldorf Astoria Kuala Lumpur on 29 October — 268 suites from 80 to 745 square metres, a 2,275-square-metre spa across two floors, and resistance bands, massage balls and a foam roller in every suite. Hilton's release publishes **no nightly rate and no explicit opening date**.

SOURCES 1 SJX (JX Su) and Deployant (Daryll Ng), both 30 October 2026, read at source. 2 Louis Erard's own homepage and duo-set product page, read 30 October — the conflict between the trade reports and the maker's own banner is printed rather than resolved. 3 SJX (Andrew Cavanaugh), 26 October 2026, and the patent filing it cites. 4 Deployant (Chester Lau) and SJX, both 24 October 2026, for the Lange announcement and the Zenith redundancies. 5 SJX's previews of the Sotheby's and Phillips Geneva sales; **Sotheby's own catalogue page returned HTTP 404 to this desk, so the lot number and estimate for the 3970 rest on a single source. Reddit and the watch forums refused this desk entirely, so there is no owner or collector sentiment on this page — every voice above is a named trade journalist writing under a byline.**

SCREEN & SOUND · LAIKA'S WILDWOOD

LAIKA's Wildwood opens third on $12.3m from 2,817 screens

The studio's best-reviewed film — 99 per cent from 154 critics, a Metascore of 88 with no negative notice — took a per-screen average of $4,356.

LAIKA's **Wildwood** opened in North America over **23–25 October 2026** on **$12,273,561** from **2,817** theatres, third in the frame, for a per-screen average of **$4,356**. Read on 30 October, its Tomatometer stood at **99 per cent from 154 critics** and its Metascore at **88 from 37 reviews** — 35 positive, two mixed, **none negative**.[1]

The notices are close to unanimous. Frank Scheck in *The Hollywood Reporter* called it "LAIKA's most ambitious effort to date" and "may also be the company's masterpiece"; Robbie Collin in *The Telegraph*, "a surpassingly beautiful and beguiling modern-day Narnia fable"; John Nugent in *Empire*, "Astonishing. An ode to outsiders and weirdos." Twenty years of hand-built stop-motion, reportedly against a budget near **$100m**, and the audience did not come.[2]

The same weekend showed what did sell. **Clayface** led on **$24,002,731** from 3,458 theatres; **HYBE Cine Fest 2026**, a K-pop concert film, entered sixth on **$4.5m**; and A24's **You Can See Everything** was the only top-five title to grow, up **25 per cent** in its second weekend to $19.5m.[1]

> *"An ode to outsiders and weirdos."*

Setting the record straight. No. 148 printed *Clayface* at **77 per cent from 193 critics**, itself a correction of a mid-count figure. Read again on 30 October it is **78 per cent from 202**. Nine more critics in twenty-four hours moved the score a point; this desk now dates every score it prints.[1]

THE CHATTER · TWENTY YEARS ON, A FIRST

My Chemical Romance's *The Black Parade* reached number one on the UK albums chart dated 30 October 2026, climbing from 162 on a twentieth-anniversary reissue. The Official Charts Company's own page now records a peak of one, where it had stood at two since the album first charted on **4 November 2006** — the band's first UK number one. The week's first midweek flash put it on **13,395 sales, 12,702 of them physical**; final first-week figures are not yet published. Fontaines D.C.'s *Dopamine Chamber* fell to two.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A HUNDRED PER CENT HIDES

Only one critic on Metacritic's roll dissents: **Alison Willmore** of *New York* magazine, at **50. This desk could not read her review — the publisher refused the request — so her score is reported and her argument is not.** Two further cautions on the numbers above. **Box Office Mojo labels the entire 23–25 October table "estimated", not actual**, and rival outlets report the same opening at $11.6m, $11.8m and "$12m", and the theatre count at 2,942 rather than 2,817. The **$100m budget, the A CinemaScore and the "second-lowest LAIKA opening" claim are each single-sourced.**[1]

$972,531

WHAT *KLARA AND THE SUN* HAD TAKEN IN NORTH AMERICA BY 30 OCTOBER, EIGHT DAYS AFTER RELEASE — $1,641,132 WORLDWIDE. IT HAS NOT CROSSED A MILLION AT HOME[4]

IN BRIEF

Street Fighter fell 72.1 per cent in its second weekend to $8,587,187 from 3,575 theatres, for $46.9m domestic.

Netflix's global film chart for 19–25 October was led by *Animals* on 10.7 million views and 19.3 million hours. The page served no television or non-English lists.

No Japanese weekend box-office ranking for 24–25 October exists at any readable source; Box Office Mojo's Japan series stops in May.

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend table for 23–25 October 2026 and its title pages, read 30 October — **the whole table is published as estimates**; Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic read the same day, counts and dates as printed. 2 Critic scores and quotations as listed on Metacritic's own page for the film. 3 The Official Charts Company's own chart and album pages for the week of 30 October 2026; the midweek sales flash via *Music Week*, 26 October, which is provisional by definition. 4 Box Office Mojo's title page for *Klara and the Sun*, read 30 October. **Billboard returned a paywall gateway and Reddit refused this desk, so there are no United States chart figures and no forum sentiment on this page; the one community line is a Letterboxd review, attributed.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE FIRST PHONE

Barzilay's Philadelphia team ties a third of the first phone's harm to one account

Of 3,486 children with no phone at twelve, 1,546 had one by thirteen — and three mediators account for about 80 per cent of the effect, published 30 September 2026.

Ziv Bren, Ran Barzilay and colleagues at the Children's Hospital of Philadelphia published on **30 September 2026** a study of exactly the decision in front of a Singapore household this month. Taking **3,486 children in the ABCD cohort who had no smartphone at twelve**, they followed which of them acquired one by thirteen — **1,546 did** — against **1,940** who stayed without.[1]

The effects are real and small. Internalising symptoms moved by a standardised **0.11 (95% CI 0.05–0.18)**, attention by **0.09**, total screen time by **0.19**, and school-day sleep fell by **−0.18**. What did **not** move is worth as much: externalising symptoms, academic performance, exercise, bullying and cyberbullying were all null.[1]

The useful finding is where the harm sits. Three mediators carry roughly **80 per cent** of the whole association: **owning a social-media account, 35.5 per cent** (odds ratio 3.22), **total screen time, 27.9**, and **bedtime media use, 16.9**. The lever is not the handset. It is an account and a bedroom.[1]

> ***The lever is not the handset. It is an account and a bedroom.***

This cuts against what this desk printed two days ago (p13), and the tension is the point rather than an error. The earlier finding was that *problematic use* does not predict depressive symptoms from twelve to thirteen; this one is that *acquiring the device at all* moves internalising symptoms by thirteen. Same cohort, same year, different exposure — which is how a literature actually behaves.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE MINISTRY ACTUALLY DID

Singapore ran the harder version of this policy first. From **January 2026**, the Ministry of Education broadened its phone and smartwatch ban from lesson time to **the whole school day — recess, co-curricular activities and supplementary lessons included** — and moved the sleep cut-off on every school learning device from **11.00pm to 10.30pm**. Asked in Parliament on **13 January 2026** about emergency contact, the ministry replied that messages go through the General Office and that **"there is no need for students to own or use a handphone"**. One concrete detail for a Secondary One kit list: a Smart Buddy watch is allowed for payment; pairing a tag with a children's phone is not.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · SINGAPORE'S OWN CHILDREN, RE-EXAMINED

On **21 October 2026**, Daphne Bavelier and Benoit Bediou's Geneva group reanalysed **Singapore's own 3,434-pupil gaming cohort** — twelve schools, three annual waves, run on Ministry of Education and media-authority money — with the original study's author, Douglas Gentile, as co-author. Splitting by how much a child already played overturns the headline: for **occasional** players, hours explained about **12 per cent** of the change in problematic gaming; for the **heaviest**, at around 57 hours a week, hours explained about **7** and it was **impulsiveness at about 11**. Cross-lagged models found **no significant within-person link between hours and harm at all**. Their words: playing time is "an incomplete index of harm"; "not all screen time is created equal". **Their own caveat: the data are from 2007–2009, before mobile and free-to-play.**[3]

Nothing published

TEN MONTHS INTO THE FULL-DAY BAN, THE MINISTRY'S STATED EVIDENCE REMAINS "SCHOOLS THAT HAVE SEEN POSITIVE OUTCOMES" — NO EVALUATION, NO EFFECT SIZE, NO COMPARISON GROUP[2]

SOURCES 1 Bren, Barzilay and colleagues, *Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry* 5:1940646, epub 30 September 2026, doi 10.3389/frcha.2026.1940646, read in full at PubMed Central. **Declared interests: the senior author sits on an uncompensated advisory board and, with equity, on a health company's scientific advisory board; a co-author's spouse holds shares in a related firm. Funding from the National Institute of Mental Health and a family foundation.** 2 The Ministry of Education's own press release of 30 November 2025 and its parliamentary reply of 13 January 2026, both read as raw source after the ordinary fetch returned empty. 3 Bediou, Bavelier and Gentile, *PLoS One* 21(10):e0356080, epub 21 October 2026, read in full at PubMed Central; the original cohort was funded in part by Singapore's Ministry of Education and the Info-communications Media Development Authority.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE TRANSITION

Vaillancourt's Ottawa team tracked 701 children and found the secondary move bends the curve

Published 15 October 2026, the eight-year study puts a significant break at the transition — and 10.6 per cent follow an increasing path from the same starting level as their peers.

Tracy Vaillancourt and Heather Brittain at the University of Ottawa published on **15 October 2026** an eight-year follow of **701 young people**, self-reporting annually from eleven to eighteen. Modelling the elementary and secondary years as separate phases, they found a **significant change in both the level and the slope of internalising symptoms at the school transition itself**.[1]

Four paths emerge. **51.8 per cent** stay low and **32.5** moderate; **5.1 per cent** decline. The group that matters is the **10.6 per cent** on an increasing path — because they **started level with everyone else** and ended at materially higher risk in early adulthood. Higher symptoms clustered among girls, lower household income, more bullying victimisation and less social support.[1]

For a Singapore household the timing is unusually exact. The **2026 PSLE results are due between 24 and 25 November** on the ministry's own calendar, with Direct School Admission allocations arriving alongside them and everyone else going to Secondary One posting. A child sitting in that window is inside the transition this research is about, roughly three weeks before it formally begins.[2]

They started level with everyone else and ended at higher risk.

There is one lever with evidence behind it and it is not academic. Li Niu and Yang Qu followed **1,977 seventh-graders, mean age 12.73**, for a year and reported on **22 October 2026** that earlier pubertal timing predicted higher depressive symptoms at **β = 0.04 (95% CI 0.01–0.08)** while **parental pubertal support** predicted lower symptoms at **β = −0.06 (−0.10 to −0.02)** — and early timing mattered **only for the girls reporting low support**. The authors call the interaction "small but significant", and this desk prints their words rather than a number, because the coefficient is not in the record. There was **no buffering effect in boys**.[3]

THE CHATTER · DON'T BE ALARMED BY THE SHRUG

If a twelve-year-old has started preferring her friends' company to yours, that is measurable, automatic and not a verdict on you. Riley Bonar and Michele Morningstar eye-tracked **85 adolescents aged 11–15** with photographs of each child's own parent and own friend, and reported on **29 October 2026** a friend-over-parent looking bias at **p < .001**, strongest where the child felt closer to the friend. **Pubertal status was unrelated to it entirely.** The pull is attentional rather than hormonal — and the one part a parent can move is relative closeness.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR PAPERS, FOUR SETS OF LIMITS

None of this is strong evidence and the desk will not dress it up. The Ottawa cohort is **one country, 76 per cent white, self-report only**, and its growth-model coefficients and confidence intervals are **not in the published record this desk could read** — the class proportions are verified, the inferential statistics are not. The puberty study runs **two waves** in an urban Chinese sample and withholds its interaction coefficient. The eye-tracking study is **85 people in a lab, cross-sectional, with a mean age of 13.2 — a year above this desk's reader** — and only p-values were available. Effect sizes throughout are small. Treat all four as directions, not instructions.[14]

24–25 Nov

WHEN THE MINISTRY'S OWN CALENDAR PLACES THE 2026 PSLE RESULTS. THE SECONDARY ONE POSTING DATE FOR 2026 IS NOT PUBLISHED, SO THIS PAGE PRINTS NONE[2]

General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Vaillancourt and Brittain, "The secondary school transition as a turning point for internalizing symptoms", *Development and Psychopathology*, online ahead of print 15 October 2026, doi 10.1017/S095457942610203X. 2 The Ministry of Education's own national-examination dates page, last updated 27 March 2026, which states the results will be released "tentatively between Tuesday, 24 November 2026 and Wednesday, 25 November 2026". 3 Niu, Qu and Chaku, *Journal of Adolescent Health*, online 22 October 2026, doi 10.1016/j.jadohealth.2026.08.023. 4 Bonar and Morningstar, *Developmental Psychology*, ahead of print 29 October 2026, doi 10.1037/dev0002289. **Where a coefficient, confidence interval or p-value is absent above, it is absent from the record this desk could read, and is reported as missing rather than estimated.**

THE MACRO DESK · PRICE RESTRICTIVE, QUANTITY EXPANDING

The Fed, the ECB and the Bank of Japan all held rates

The Fed held at 3.75–4.00 per cent on 28 October ten votes to two, the ECB at 2.50 on the 29th, and the Bank of Japan at 1.25 on the 30th, eight to one.

In seventy-two hours the three central banks that matter all left their policy rate alone, and in all three the dissent ran the same way. The **Federal Reserve held at 3.75–4.00 per cent on 28 October by ten votes to two, Lisa Cook and Beth Hammack both preferring a quarter-point rise**. The **European Central Bank held on 29 October**, its deposit rate at **2.50** into September inflation of **3.8 per cent**. The **Bank of Japan held at around 1.25 per cent on 30 October, eight to one, Hajime Takata** dissenting for **1.50**. **Not one dissenter wanted a cut.**[1]

And yet the quantity of money is being added to. The Fed's implementation note of the same day instructs the Desk, "when appropriate, [to] increase the System Open Market Account holdings of securities through purchases of Treasury bills", and to **"reinvest all principal payments from… agency securities into Treasury bills"**. In Tokyo the mirror image: the Bank held the rate and **unanimously more than doubled its ETF sell-down, from about ¥330bn a year to about ¥860bn** from January 2027. **The price of money is restrictive. The quantity is not.**[2]

The week's market move was not about any of it. **The S&P 500 fell 1.82 per cent on Friday to 7,580.07** and the Nasdaq Composite had its worst month since March 2025, with **Intel down 29 per cent in a day**. The repricing is of AI capital spending, not of inflation (p7).[3]

A bull steepening with pinned breakevens is a growth repricing, not a disinflation.

The curve proves it. Across the week the **two-year fell 13 basis points to 4.56** and the **ten-year six, to 4.94**, steepening 2s10s from **+31 to +38**. But the **ten-year breakeven did not move at all — 2.34 per cent on 23 October, 2.34 on the 30th** — while the **ten-year real yield fell from 2.66 to 2.60**. The entire rally was in the real leg. That is growth being marked down, not inflation.[4]

THE LEVELS · FRIDAY 30 OCTOBER

US 10-year[4]	4.94%	▼ 4bp
VWRA	$188.54	▼ 1.43%
S&P 500	7,580.07	▼ 1.82%
Gold	$3,874.40	▼ 3.63%
Bitcoin[5]	$76,627	▼ 1.5%
STI	5,376.74	▼ 0.36%

Bitcoin is a level at 21:20 UTC, not a close — its daily candle was still open. Explanation, not advice.[5]

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

Bonds did their job and hard assets did not. Against equities down 1.82 per cent, **BNDW rose 0.17** and the global aggregate 0.16: on the day the equity–bond correlation was negative and a sixty-forty portfolio hedged properly. **Gold fell 3.63 per cent on a day its own opportunity cost fell three basis points** — which is not a macro move but a positioning one — and silver fell 5.84. **Bitcoin fell on a theft** (p3), not on a rate. The regime: **higher-for-longer with a supply-shock inflation core, now cut across by a growth scare in AI capital spending**. Not dollar-bid: the dollar index moved **0.07 per cent**. Not liquidity-tight. Not easing.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · BRENT, RECONCILED AT LAST

No. 148 could not reconcile Brent across four sources and printed the 28th. **The gap was never an error: two different series are in circulation.** The physical dated assessment printed **US$123.10 on 27 October**; the front-month future settled **$112.33 on the 30th** — a physical premium of eight to eleven dollars. **The government's own series has no print after 27 October, and the equity level above is single-sourced, with three feeds about three points apart.**[5]

SOURCES 1 The Federal Reserve's own statement of 28 October 2026; the ECB's own monetary-policy statement of 29 October; the Bank of Japan's own Statement on Monetary Policy of 30 October, read as published, including the vote and the dissenting proposal. 2 The FOMC implementation note of 28 October, quoted verbatim; the Bank of Japan's ETF decision of 30 October, with the market-value conversion given in its own footnote. 3 Reuters' market wire of 30 October for the equity moves. 4 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield-curve files, row 30 October 2026 — **the breakeven and the 2s10s spread are this desk's own arithmetic on those two primary curves, not quoted series**. 5 Gold double-sourced; Brent double-sourced for the future and taken from the energy agency's own series for the physical; bitcoin read directly from two exchange interfaces; **the equity index, the index-tracking fund price and the Straits Times Index are each single-sourced, because the exchanges' own pages returned authentication errors, 403s or browser notices. Market explanation and education, not investment advice; forecasts are flagged as forecasts.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · AMATEUR PERFUMERY

Perfumer's Apprentice sells Dior's palette in four-millilitre bottles at $6

Hedione costs six dollars for four millilitres and ninety-five for a kilogram — the same ladder as Iso E Super — and r/DIYfragrance grew 48.7 per cent in a year, to about 51,000.

Amateur perfumery is formulation chemistry done by weight on a kitchen table. The hobbyist buys single odorant materials — synthetic aroma chemicals from the four great houses, and naturals — weighs them to a thousandth of a gram, builds an oil concentrate, and dilutes it in ethanol to somewhere between fifteen and twenty-five per cent.[1]

The subversive fact underneath it is that the materials are not special. They are the same ones professionals use, sold in four- and fifteen-millilitre decants. **Perfumer's Apprentice** lists Firmenich's **Hedione** at **$6.00** for 4ml and **$95.00** for a kilogram — the identical ladder as IFF's **Iso E Super**. Both run to **five kilos for $423**; Hedione goes to **fifty kilos for $2,950**, on a three-week lead time. A hobbyist can buy half a drum of the molecule underneath most modern fine fragrance.[1]

There are three documented doors in. The first is a discovery kit: Perfumer's Apprentice sells an introduction at **$69**, a beginner's aromachemical kit at **$155**, and "Classic Perfumery Ingredients" at **$259** — fifty materials, fifty pipettes and two hundred scent strips, sold explicitly as "a small beginner's perfumery organ", with **no book and no instructions**.[2]

The second is a supplier who teaches. **Sam Macer** founded what became The Fragrance Foundry in 2019 and began posting perfumery lessons to YouTube; his own account of why is the most honest sentence in the hobby's commercial literature — he was "frustrated with the lack of accessible and professional information about perfumery online", and some of his early purchases were "a complete waste of money and time".[3]

> ***"A painter with ten thousand pigments but no blue has a larger palette than Vermeer."***

The third door is a grievance. Perfumes get reformulated out from under the people who love them, and those people go looking for the materials. **Linda Pilkington** of Ormonde Jayne counts nine discontinued scents she calls her "Sleeping Beauties"; **Roja Dove**, on a restricted material, complains that "basil has for years been considered this dangerous material in specific concentrations", which he finds irrational given how much of it chefs cook with.[4]

THE CHATTER · HOW BIG, AND GROWING HOW FAST

r/DIYfragrance stands at about **51,000 members, up 17,000 — 48.7 per cent — in a year**; the far smaller, far more technical **r/perfumery** is near 2,000, up 34.7 per cent. For scale, the adjacent essential-oils hobby grew 13.5 per cent over the same period: **DIY fragrance is growing roughly three and a half times faster than its neighbour. These counts come from a third-party Reddit analytics tracker, not from Reddit, which refused this desk entirely — do not read them as "Reddit says".**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THERE IS NO MARKET NUMBER

This desk looked for a credible size for the DIY-fragrance market and declines to print one. Grand View Research's own fragrance page now reads "The information you are looking for is currently being developed", and the estimates circulating for 2025 range from **$2.92bn to $9.2bn** depending on definition — all of them from vendor blogs. The better evidence is behavioural: the subreddit growth above, and an awards programme that in its twelfth year needed a **three-stage blind judging process with 26 named judges**.[6]

What follows goes down two more pages: where these people gather and what they argue about; the gear, from a six-dollar decant to a two-thousand-euro bottle of aged oud; what the hobby actually costs at four levels of seriousness; and the regulation everyone blames, which turns out not to bind an amateur at all.

SOURCES 1 Perfumer's Apprentice's own aroma-chemical price pages, read at source. 2 Its own educational-kits page, including the "no book or instructions" wording. 3 The Fragrance Foundry's own About page. 4 Melanie McDonagh, *The Spectator*, issue of 28 March 2026, quoting Pilkington and Dove. 5 GummySearch's subreddit pages for r/DIYfragrance and r/perfumery, pulled 25 and 30 October 2026 — **a third-party tracker, because Reddit itself was unreachable from this desk**. 6 Grand View Research's own fragrance-market page; the Art and Olfaction Awards' own winners release of 11 June 2026. **The pull quote is from an unsigned essay published by a perfume brand with a commercial interest in the argument; it is quoted as rhetoric, not evidence.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE GEAR AND THE GRAIL

Oud Assafi costs $597 for four millilitres; its five-per-cent dilution costs $48.50

A serious palette runs to about £365 in Britain or $645 in America — plus a $273.50 hazmat fee on every order shipped out of the United States.

The working palette is cheap and the top of it is not. In the middle sit the materials a formula is actually built from: **Cashmeran** at $7.00 for 4ml and $204.50 a kilo, **Habanolide** at $6.25 and $153.50, **Clearwood** at $6.75, **Helional** at $6.50, **Ambroxan at ten per cent in DPG** at $6.00. Coumarin crystals are **$6.00 for eight grams**.[1]

Above them is the expensive drawer. **Javanol** is $15.50 for 4ml but **$1,297 a kilo**; **Ambrocenide crystals** are **$62 for eight grams**; **Cosmone** reaches **$2,318 a kilo**; **Methyl Jasmonate** is **$46.25** for four millilitres. And then the naturals, which is where the hobby turns into collecting: **Orris Butter at fifteen per cent irones, $94.25 for 4ml and $849.75 for fifty grams**; **Mysore sandalwood at $2,065 for 500g**; Bulgarian rose otto at **$339** for 15ml; and **Oud Assafi at $597 for four millilitres** — the single most expensive listing per millilitre on the reference price list.[1]

The discipline the catalogue teaches is dilution. Almost nothing is smelled or weighed neat: the shelf is mostly solvent, and the same Oud Assafi is sold at **five per cent in triethyl citrate for $48.50**, Bulgarian rose at ten per cent for **$9.00**, orris as a twenty-per-cent tincture for **$24.75**. The first justified luxury in this hobby is a dilution, not a bottle.[1]

"Overdosed, it easily dominates a formula."

Equipment is a shorter list than the materials. A **500g by 0.001g analytical balance runs £120** with a calibration weight and a draft shield; the mid-range 320g version is **from £270**. Scent strips are **100 for $7.00** or **5,000 for $195**; a hundred four-millilitre vials with caps, **$73**; a three-tier perfumer's rack, **£50**. There is no such product as a perfumer's organ: it is assembled, not bought.[2]

Commissioning is the tier above making. **Wit & West** publishes a bespoke perfume at **$850**, three phases of edits, **three to six months**, delivering two 15ml bottles and one of 50ml. In Singapore, **Maison 21G** charges **S$200 a guest** for an hour and a 30ml eau de parfum, and **Sifr Aromatics on Arab Street** is reported to start near **S$250 — a figure this desk could not confirm, because the shop's own domain would not resolve. Telephone before quoting it.**[3]

THE CHATTER · THE BENCH, REVIEWED BY ITS OWNERS

On the balance that most hobbyists buy, **Tina Torstensson**: "The scale itself is highly accurate, and I really like the protective acrylic draft shield that comes with it." **VITALIY**, less sold: "My only complaint is the plastic draft shield, which could be made from better quality materials." **Matthew Bradshaw**: "These where a great introduction to my start up lab." On a £199.99 thirty-material starter kit, **Basit Wahab**: "The quality of the materials are great, the quantity is also great to get familiar with the materials."[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE KILO TRAP AND THE THIRD DECIMAL

Two money pits are visible in the catalogue itself. **The ladder is engineered to make bulk look rational to someone who will never use it**: Iso E Super is $11 for 15ml and $95 for a kilogram — sixty-five times the volume for 8.6 times the money. A hobbyist formulating ten-gram trials will use grams a year. **A kilo of Iso E Super is roughly a century of supply.** And the balance: the £120 three-decimal model is specified by its own maker at **repeatability ±0.002g and linear error ±0.002g** — twice its display resolution. In an unairconditioned room it is a two-decimal balance wearing a costume.[2]

$273.50

PERFUMER'S APPRENTICE'S 2026 INTERNATIONAL HAZMAT FEE, PER ORDER, UP FROM $256.75 — MOST OF THE USEFUL PALETTE IS A DANGEROUS GOOD THAT NO POSTAL SERVICE WILL CARRY. THE SIX-DOLLAR BOTTLE IS A TWO-HUNDRED-AND-EIGHTY-DOLLAR BOTTLE[4]

SOURCES 1 Perfumer's Apprentice's own aroma-chemical, essential-oil and absolute price pages, read at source across four alphabetical tabs. 2 The Fragrance Foundry's own balance, kit and equipment pages, including the manufacturer's published tolerances and the reviews quoted, each read on the product page carrying it. 3 Wit & West's own bespoke FAQ; Maison 21G's own Singapore pricing; the Sifr Aromatics figure is from an undated third-party listing and is flagged in the text as unconfirmed. 4 Perfumer's Apprentice's own shipping page, which also records a 15 per cent restocking fee if customs refuses a parcel, and no refund on abandonment. **Hermitage Oils ships to Singapore by courier at €38.99 on a €200 order and €29.99 on a €350 order, with no free-shipping threshold for this country; its 1990 wild Bhutan oud is listed at €2,307.69.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE RULE NOBODY READS

IFRA's own UK director says its standards bind only its members

The 52nd Amendment closed consultation on 31 August 2026 and withdrew two proposed restrictions outright — notification is expected in January 2027.

Every grievance in this hobby runs through three letters. The International Fragrance Association sets the restrictions that reformulate perfumes, and the amateur's assumption is that they are law. They are not. **Lisa Hipgrave**, director of IFRA UK, on the record: the standards "are not a legal requirement and only mandatory to Ifra members". **A hobbyist making perfume for themselves is bound by none of it.**[1]

The current amendment is the 51st; the **52nd closed consultation on 31 August 2026** and is expected to be notified in **January 2027**, in force eleven months later for new creations. It brings **48 new restriction standards** and **15 revisions**; the furocoumarins standard is set at **1ppm** for products meant for deliberate sun exposure.[2]

And it cuts both ways, which the grievance literature leaves out. The consultation **withdrew two proposed standards outright** and **postponed a third**. That falsifies the most-quoted line in the complaint: "No amendment has ever loosened a restriction. The ratchet turns in one direction only." The chemistry is real, too — oakmoss's sensitisers were identified by a named Danish group, as the ratchet essay concedes.[2]

> ***"Removing or changing one material impacts the entire architecture of a scent."***

What bites an amateur is not the standard but the label: much of the palette is a dangerous good, shipped by two couriers only, into a home with no fume hood. The second constraint is commercial — the moment a hobbyist sells one bottle, conformity becomes a line item, from a **$100** safety data sheet to contract compounding at **$129** with a one-kilogram minimum.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE CRAFT IS JUDGED

The hobby's formal ladder is the Art and Olfaction Awards, whose twelfth edition ran in **Athens on 11 June 2026** with **Luca Turin** among the judges in the final round. **Grant Osborne**, who has run Basenotes for twenty-five years, took its Contribution to Scent Culture award. **The thirteenth edition goes to Mexico City in May 2027; submissions close on 20 November 2026.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · YOU WILL NOT MATCH THE PROFESSIONAL

The argument is real, and it is structural rather than snobbish. **Captives**: materials no amateur can buy at any price. **The library, not the materials**: Perfumer's Apprentice rents its lab and fragrance library at **$750 a day**, and **only to "established artisan, independent, and niche perfumers"**. And reverse engineering mostly fails: the same firm sells **GC-MS at $350** and says up front it "will not provide specific concentrations". **Amateurs do not beat professionals at the professional game — they win an adjacent one, which Luca Turin now judges.**[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Ikebana — rival Japanese schools, a licence ladder of their own, and shears that cost more than the flowers.

Pigeon racing — electronic clocking, million-euro bloodlines and a Belgian auction house that sets the price.

Letterpress & hand bookbinding — cast type, platen presses and a trade that never fully died.

In Singapore the first piece of equipment is not a balance. It is an air-conditioned, dark cupboard: the materials degrade in heat, the balance is rated to forty degrees, and citrus oils dissolve the rubber in the droppers they are sold with.[6]

SOURCES 1 Lisa Hipgrave, quoted in *The Spectator*, 28 March 2026; Thierry Wasser of Guerlain in the same article supplies the pull quote. 2 IFRA's own End of Consultation Letter for the 52nd Amendment, dated 31 August 2026, and its own news index, read at source; the ratchet quotation is from an unsigned essay of 29 December 2025 published by a perfume brand. 3 Perfumer's Apprentice's own services page for the regulatory and compounding prices; Formulair's own site and PerfumersWorld's own training page for the free tiers. 4 The Art and Olfaction Awards' own winners release of 11 June 2026 and the Institute for Art and Olfaction's own homepage, read at source. 5 Perfumer's Apprentice's own lab-rental and GC-MS listings; Osmo's own site for the captives auction. 6 Perfumer's Apprentice's own warning on dropper materials; the balance's published 5–40°C working range. **Reddit, Basenotes and the Fragrantica forums all refused this desk, so no thread is quoted anywhere across these three pages; every voice is a named person on a page this magazine could read. Singapore's customs rules make undenatured ethanol dutiable and permit-bound, and the denaturants that make alcohol duty-free are precisely the ones that smell — the local hobbyist's hardest problem is not materials but solvent.**

FITNESS · THE RECLASSIFICATION STUDY

Myers and Kokkinos link each extra MET to 16 per cent lower mortality

Published 6 October 2026, the ETHOS analysis puts adjusted ten-year mortality at 32.9 per cent in the unfit against 13.4 in the fit — and raises the model's discrimination by 0.020.

Jonathan Myers, Peter Kokkinos and colleagues published on **6 October 2026** an analysis of **562,234 adults** with complete covariates, followed for a mean of **10.2 years**, testing whether cardiorespiratory fitness adds anything to the risk factors clinicians already use. Each additional metabolic equivalent cut the hazard of death by **16 per cent** — a hazard ratio of **0.84, with a confidence interval of 0.838 to 0.842**.[1]

The headline contrast is enormous: adjusted ten-year mortality of **32.9 per cent in the unfit against 13.4 per cent in the fit**. Read the next number beside it. Adding fitness to the model moved its discrimination — its ability to tell who dies from who does not — from **0.662 to 0.682**. A gain of **0.020**. Both figures are true, and only one of them is the clinical size of the finding.[1]

Two limits matter for a reader in his forties who trains. "Unfit" here means the **lowest quintile, below 5.0 METs** — a very low bar, and not his comparison. And the cohort is people referred for a treadmill test, which is a clinical population, not a general one. The abstract reports no number of deaths and carries no limitations section at all.[1]

A confidence interval that narrow is a product of the sample, not of precision about any person.

A cleaner result ran three weeks earlier and will be less popular. Reza Bagheri and colleagues randomised **108 women aged 40 to 77** across twelve supervised weeks to **0.8, 1.6 or 2.2 grams of protein per kilogram**, with resistance or concurrent training. On the primary outcome — skeletal muscle mass — there was nothing: a protein main effect of **p = 0.726** and an interaction of **p = 0.856**. The authors state the honest version themselves: **"Null protein findings do not establish equivalence among doses."** Muscle was measured by bioelectrical impedance, and 83 of the 108 completed.[2]

THE CHATTER · THE DISCOURSE IS ARGUING THE OTHER WAY

While a randomised trial finds no dose effect, the training internet is pushing the number up. **Greg Nuckols** of Stronger by Science argues the 1.6–2.2g consensus is too *conservative*, and makes the case against his own side's evidence: of the meta-analysis everyone cites, **"the breakpoint itself wasn't even statistically significant (p = 0.079)"**. He proposes a breakpoint nearer **2.0g/kg**, scaled to fat-free mass. **Peter Attia** holds that hypertrophy does not plateau below 1.6. **Donald Layman** puts the optimum at **1.2 to 1.6** — below both. Three named positions, one randomised null, no consensus.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · ELEVEN PEOPLE, NO CONTROL GROUP

The clearest example of how this literature goes wrong came out on **19 September**: a retrospective chart review of weight-loss drug users with structured exercise reported that lean mass fell only **0.62kg, p = 0.397** — not significant — while fat fell 4.37kg. It is being read as evidence that lean mass was preserved. It is **eleven people, single-centre, with no control group**, and **four of its seven authors are affiliated with the concierge-longevity company where it was conducted**, which they declare. An underpowered null is not a positive result. The authors themselves call it "hypothesis-generating". **This is the reader's own optimisation industry producing research about itself.**[4]

Not significant

RESISTANCE TRAINING ALONE, ON SYSTOLIC PRESSURE, IN A 26-STUDY META-ANALYSIS OF 1,576 PEOPLE. AEROBIC WORK MOVED BOTH NUMBERS; LIFTING ALONE DID NOT MOVE THE TOP ONE[5]

SOURCES 1 Myers, Kokkinos and colleagues, "Cardiorespiratory Fitness Reclassifies Mortality Risk Beyond Traditional Risk Factors: The ETHOS Study", *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise*, online ahead of print 6 October 2026, doi 10.1249/MSS.0000000000004175. **This is a different cohort and a different journal from the VO2max item this desk ran two days ago; it is not that study restated.** 2 Bagheri and colleagues, *Journal of the International Society of Sports Nutrition* 23(1):2720742, epub 14 September 2026. No conflicts declared. 3 Nuckols at Stronger by Science, with his July 2025 update; Attia and Layman's stated positions. 4 *Obesity Pillars*, epub 19 September 2026, doi 10.1016/j.obpill.2026.100335 — affiliations declared by the authors. 5 Bappah and colleagues, *Frontiers in Cardiovascular Medicine*, 13 October 2026, doi 10.3389/fcvm.2026.1908252; substantial heterogeneity across most analyses, and the abstract reports no I^2 values. **No new validation study for either of the wearables this desk tracks was published in September or October 2026; the most recent remains a six-study meta-analysis from November 2025, which found no significant difference from polysomnography on any of seven measures and which contradicts itself on staging accuracy between its introduction and its discussion.**

DEPARTURES · THE CABIN AND THE CAUSEWAY

Singapore Airlines unveils four new cabins in November

The first refitted A350 returns in the first quarter of 2027, and all 41 aircraft are not due until the end of 2030 — about 27 per cent of a 153-aircraft fleet.

Singapore Airlines showed the first glimpses of its next-generation First and Business cabins on **22 October 2026**, with the complete product — four new cabins — to be unveiled **in Singapore in November**. The new entertainment system goes to **34 A350 Long Haul aircraft, seven A350 ULRs and 31 777-9s on order**; the **41 A350s** to be refitted are roughly **27 per cent** of the 153-aircraft passenger fleet.[1]

The dates are the story for anyone booking. The first refitted A350 Long Haul returns to service in the **first quarter of 2027**, having slipped from an earlier expectation of the second quarter of 2026, and all 41 refits are targeted only **by the end of 2030**. The 2013 Business seat finally has an end date; most of the fleet will not see the replacement this decade. Screens go to **32 inches** in First and **22** in Business, from 18 today; Bluetooth reaches all cabins on the 777-9. Starlink is being fitted to **53 aircraft from early 2027**, complete by the end of 2029.[1]

The **Johor Bahru–Singapore Rapid Transit System** has slipped again, to **February 2027**, announced by the operator on **2 October** — from end-2026, then January. Woodlands North station was completed on **4 September 2026**; testing runs to December. The line is **4.0km** with two stations and a roughly **five-minute** ride, designed for **10,000 passengers an hour** each way and 40,000 a day at opening. **Fares are still not set**; a February 2026 indication from Malaysia's transport minister put a journey at **RM15.50–21.70**. **This desk could not reach the primary announcement — the operator's site and two outlets refused it — so the February date is reported, not confirmed.**[2]

Chinese New Year falls on 16 February 2027. The line may open the same month.

Japan's tax-free shopping changes **tomorrow, 1 November 2026**, from a deduction at the till to **pay now, refund later** at the airport. And the **Jetstar Asia** file is closed: the carrier is gone, which removes a set of regional routings a Singapore flyer used to assume.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT CHANGED AT CHANGI

The northern-winter schedule change on **25 October** brought a lounge reshuffle at Changi, and Singapore Airlines launched **Singapore–Barcelona–Madrid on 26 October**, five times weekly on an A350-900 — a twenty-two-year absence ended, and this magazine's own call from No. 79 settled right (p2). Against it, the Milan–Barcelona tag has been dropped. Scoot has opened **Guiyang**, and the group ran a fare sale of some **380,000 tickets**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE REVEAL IS NOT THE SEAT

A November unveiling is a photograph, not a product. The thing a reader can act on is which tail number they are booked on, and that will not change for most routes until **2027 at the earliest** and for most of the fleet until **2030**. Two further honesty notes: **Singapore Airlines' own newsroom is bot-blocked to this desk**, so every figure above is read at a specialist title reporting the airline's statement rather than at the statement itself; and on loyalty, **there is no news in this window at all** — no devaluation, no chart change — which after a year of them is itself worth recording.[1]

€20

THE ETIAS FEE, NOW CONFIRMED — BUT THE SCHEME STILL HAS NO START DATE, A YEAR AFTER THE LAST ONE LAPSED[3]

IN BRIEF

Singapore Airlines puts the A380 on Auckland year-round — a first for the route.

Changi Terminal 5 — the official line remains unglamorous: construction, no opening date brought forward.

Manila, 14–18 November 2026 — disruption worth planning around now if a routing touches it.

SOURCES 1 Mainly Miles, 22 October 2026, reporting Singapore Airlines' own statement and briefing — **the airline's own newsroom refused this desk, so the release itself was not read**. 2 The operator's announcement of 2 October 2026 as carried in the public record; **the operator's own site and two reporting outlets all refused the request, and the February 2027 date should be re-checked against the land transport authority before anyone books around it**. 3 Japan's tax-free reform effective 1 November 2026; the ETIAS fee as published, with no commencement date set. 4 Changi's northern-winter schedule change of 25 October; the Madrid launch of 26 October, five times weekly on an A350-900.

DEPARTURES · LUANG PRABANG RAISES THE GATE

Luang Prabang trebles its museum ticket to 200,000 kip on 15 November

Kuang Si goes up 67 per cent and Mount Phou Si doubles — in a year when arrivals over Lao New Year fell 46 per cent against 2025.

Luang Prabang's tourism authority has published new admission prices effective **15 November 2026**, and they are not small adjustments. The **Royal Palace Museum goes from 60,000 to 200,000 kip** for a foreign visitor — a rise of **233 per cent**. **Kuang Si waterfall** rises from 60,000 to **100,000**; **Mount Phou Si** and the **Pak Ou caves** both double, to **60,000** each.[1]

Lao nationals are treated differently, and the gap is the point. The museum for a Lao visitor goes from 10,000 to **20,000 kip**; Phou Si from 10,000 to 15,000; **Kuang Si and Pak Ou do not rise at all** for locals, holding at 20,000 and 15,000. Children under twelve are free at Kuang Si and under sevens at Phou Si. At **22,372 kip to the dollar** on 30 October, the museum moves from about **US$2.70 to US$8.90**.[1]

What makes this more than a price list is when it lands. Luang Prabang took **2,306,375 visitors in 2024**, of whom 1,532,394 were international, with China, Thailand and South Korea its three largest markets. Then, over **Lao New Year, 10–20 April 2026**, the town took **68,126 visitors against 126,846 a year earlier — a fall of 46 per cent**. Revenue halved, from US$97.5m to **US$52.2m**. International arrivals were down 42 per cent and domestic down 48; **Thai visitors, the biggest regional market after China, fell 75 per cent.**[2]

A town raising its prices into a demand slump.

So the conventional reading of this place — a UNESCO town being loved to death — does not match its own numbers. 2024 was the peak. 2026 is a slump. And into that slump the province, which has a published plan aiming at ten million visitors by 2029, has trebled the ticket to its single most-visited building.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE RAIL DID

The Laos–China Railway put Luang Prabang within a short ride of Vientiane and the Chinese border, and the arrivals mix shows where that pointed: Chinese visitors over Lao New Year 2026 were **up 105 per cent** — to just **2,102** people. The railway has changed who arrives far more than how many.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · ONE NUMBER THIS DESK WILL NOT PRINT

A provincial report circulating from September puts first-half 2026 arrivals at just over a million, down **884,775** year on year. **This magazine is not printing it as fact.** The site carrying it returned a bandwidth error and could not be read at source, and the figure does not reconcile with the 824,000 recorded for January to April. The New Year collapse and the 2024 baseline above are solid and independently published; that one is not. A second caution: **festival dates here are lunar and shift every year** — the 2027 calendar is not verified, and the dates circulating for next April and October should not be booked against.[2]

+233%

THE FOREIGNER PRICE RISE AT THE ROYAL PALACE MUSEUM FROM 15 NOVEMBER. THE LAO-NATIONAL PRICE RISES 100 PER CENT — FROM 10,000 KIP TO 20,000[1]

ALSO WORTH KNOWING

Japan Rail Pass — the gap between buying direct and buying through an agent has opened up again; check both before committing.

Ski-country and Japanese hotel openings are clustered for this winter; Niseko's own season date of 28 November is marked *tentative* by the resort, and every Hakuba resort read **0cm** on 31 October (p23).

SOURCES 1 The Luang Prabang tourism authority's own attraction pages for the National Museum, Kuang Si, Phou Si and the Pak Ou caves, each carrying the line "New prices effective November 15, 2026", read at source; the exchange rate at 30 October 2026. 2 The 2024 arrivals and revenue from the provincial department of information, culture and tourism as reported in January 2025; the Lao New Year 2026 comparison as reported on 27 April 2026, both read at source. **The September provincial figure is deliberately omitted: its host returned a bandwidth error and it does not reconcile with the published January–April total.**

THE GRAND TOUR · LUANG PRABANG

Luang Prabang province led Laos in fire hotspots through the 2026 burning season

On 1 April the province recorded 220 of the country's 895 hotspots in a day, and the environment ministry put it above 200 on the air quality index.

The honest answer to when you should go to Luang Prabang is November to February, and the honest reason is not the rain. From the 1991–2020 normals, the dry months are mild — **December and January fall to about 15°C overnight** and the hills can feel colder, with most guesthouses unheated. **April is the hottest month at 35.2°C**, and the wet season peaks in **August at 329mm**.[1]

What the weather tables do not say is that the dry months end in smoke. **Luang Prabang province led the entire country in fire hotspots** during the 2026 burning season: on **1 April alone the province recorded 220** of the **895 counted nationwide that day**, out of **16,395 in the first quarter**. On **3 April** the Lao agriculture and environment ministry reported fine-particulate levels above the safe standard **in every province**, with **Luang Prabang among the three worst in the country, above 200** on the air quality index. The official advice was to wear masks and avoid exercising outdoors.[2]

So the trap is specific and it is the one a Singapore family would walk into: a trip booked for the Easter school holidays is a trip booked into the worst air in South-East Asia, under a sky the forecast calls dry and hot. For contrast, the same station read a **US index of 65** at four in the morning on **31 October** — the day this issue went out.[2]

The weather page says dry season. The sky is brown.

There is no non-stop from Singapore and there never has been. What flies into Luang Prabang is **Bangkok Airways** from Suvarnabhumi, **Thai AirAsia** from Don Mueang, **Lao Airlines** from Chiang Mai, Hanoi and Vientiane, **Vietnam Airlines** from Hanoi and Siem Reap, and **China Eastern** from Kunming. The airport is **four kilometres** from the centre with a single 2,500-metre runway, and Lao Airlines' winter timetable runs **25 October to 27 March**.[3]

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY · THREE HONEST VERDICTS

On **Kuang Si**, the consensus is go early and expect company: David Astley calls it "very pretty" but crowded and "less spectacular than some Thai falls"; Jennifer Varner, writing in May 2026, found it "more developed and commercialized than I expected". On the **Pak Ou caves**, Astley is blunt: "They are nothing special and quite small and get very crowded" — the official page itself concedes of the upper cave that "there is not much inside". **The Mekong boat ride is the experience; the caves are the excuse.** And on the Royal Palace Museum, Varner found "the experience felt somewhat diluted by the constant flow of large tour groups" — which is the building whose ticket trebles on 15 November (p20).[4]

THE SCEPTIC · NOT ONE ROOM RATE

This desk could not verify a single current nightly rate for any hotel in Luang Prabang, and says so rather than estimating one. Amantaka publishes 24 suites at the foot of Mount Phou Si and no prices; Rosewood publishes six room types in the Nahm Dong valley, waterfalls running through the grounds, promotions of **35 per cent off flexible rates for stays through July 2027** — and no prices. Avani+, Azerai, Sofitel, 3 Nagas, Satri House and Villa Maly all refused the request outright. The only accommodation figure that could be stood up anywhere is a traveller's own report of about **US$27 a night** for a suite in May 2026, which tells you the range in this town is enormous and little else.[5]

22,372

KIP TO THE US DOLLAR ON 30 OCTOBER 2026 — THE NUMBER THAT TURNS EVERY PRICE ON THESE TWO PAGES INTO SOMETHING A VISITOR RECOGNISES[1]

SOURCES 1 The 1991–2020 climate normals for Luang Prabang, elevation 305m; the Lao tourism authority's own basic-information page for the seasonal guidance and the unheated-guesthouse warning; the exchange rate at 30 October 2026. 2 *Laotian Times*, 3 April 2026, reporting the Ministry of Agriculture and Environment's own hotspot and particulate figures, read at source; the 31 October reading from a public monitoring station. **A multi-year monthly air-quality history was not used: its host returned HTTP 403 and the figures could not be read at source.** 3 The airport's scheduled-service record and Lao Airlines' own published winter timetable, effective 25 October 2026 to 27 March 2027. 4 Named first-hand accounts by David Astley and Jennifer Varner, the latter dated May 2026; the Luang Prabang tourism authority's own page for the Pak Ou concession. 5 The hotels' own sites, read where they could be read; six properties refused the request and are named as such in the text.

THE GRAND TOUR · THE RITUAL AND THE RULES

Luang Prabang's UNESCO listing protects 820 hectares of buildings, not the alms walk

The tourism authority asks visitors to stay five metres back and use no flash — the 1995 inscription covers the built town and a 12,560-hectare buffer, and the ritual is not separately listed.

Every morning before six, a line of monks walks the peninsula collecting rice. The town's own tourism authority publishes the etiquette more sharply than most guidebooks: observe **in silence**, stay **at least five metres away**, no physical contact, shoulders and legs covered, and — twice over — **"camera flashes are very disturbing for both monks and the lay people"** and **"do not stand too close to the monks when taking photographs"**. Large buses are **forbidden** inside the heritage site, and following the procession from one is disrespectful because it puts you above the monks.[1]

Times shift with the season: about **05:30 to 06:30 from March to October**, **06:00 to 07:00 from November to February**. The main points are in front of **Wat Xieng Thong**, the primary school and the National Museum. Buy sticky rice at the market earlier that morning rather than from the baskets sold at the roadside — and give only if it means something to you; otherwise the correct act is to stand well back.[1]

Here is the structural point, and the honest argument of this deep dive. **Luang Prabang's 1995 inscription covers the built town — 820 hectares** with a **12,560-hectare buffer**. The alms round is **intangible** and **not separately inscribed**. The rules can govern a facade; they have no hold over a ritual — which is why the complaints, from flash photography on novices to hotels selling alms packages, have run a decade without resolution.[2]

A listing can govern a facade. It has no hold over a ritual.

Where the money should go is a live argument among people who love the place. One writer urges readers to spend at locally-owned hotels and restaurants and to avoid the international chains "like the plague" — strongly put, honestly held, and one person's view. The craft economy makes that concrete: **Ock Pop Tok** publishes class prices valid to September 2027 — **silk weaving $58 to $225**, **natural dyeing $59**, **bamboo weaving $32** for a half day — and a shop running from a **$32 scarf** to a **$519 wall hanging**.[3]

THE CHATTER · FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD

The family case is better than the listicles suggest, and it is mostly outdoors. **Kuang Si** is free for under-twelves and has the **Tat Kuang Si Bear Rescue Centre inside the park with no separate ticket** — run by a charity operating five sanctuaries across Cambodia, Laos and Vietnam with more than 350 bears in care. **Mount Phou Si is 328 steps** and free for under-sevens; climb it at dawn rather than at the sunset crush. The Royal Palace's sleeper exhibit is the royal garage — a Lincoln Continental, an Edsel, a Citroën and a Jeep — and the Ramayana plays in the grounds on Mondays, Wednesdays, Fridays and Saturdays at **150,000 to 250,000 kip**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS DESK WOULD NOT ASSERT

Three things. **No official position on alms tourism from UNESCO or from the monastic community could be read at source** — the inscription details above come from the sourced public record because UNESCO's own page refused the request twice. **No position is therefore attributed to the Sangha here**, and at least one account reports a senior monk saying he does not mind visitors taking part, which is worth knowing before anyone writes a sermon. And the **2027 festival dates are lunar and unverified**: the circulating dates for next April and October are not sourced and should not be booked against. **Boun That Luang, often listed in roundups of this town, is a Vientiane festival and does not appear on Luang Prabang's own calendar at all.**[2]

SOURCES 1 The Luang Prabang tourism authority's own morning-alms page, read at source, including the quoted etiquette and the seasonal times. 2 The inscription figures from the sourced public record for the World Heritage property — **UNESCO's own site returned HTTP 403 to this desk on two attempts, so no position is attributed to it here**; the festival calendar from the tourism authority's own annual listing, with 2027 dates flagged as unverified because the official dated listing returned a bandwidth error. 3 Ock Pop Tok's own class and shop pages, prices valid 1 October 2026 to 30 September 2027. 4 The tourism authority's own pages for Kuang Si, Mount Phou Si and the National Museum; the bear centre's operator publishes network-wide figures but **no Luang Prabang bear count. The museum's own page gives conflicting closing times in its header and body; both Kuang Si and Pak Ou do the same, and this desk prints the body figure and says so.**

THE DIARY · TWO DEADLINES IN NOVEMBER

The National Gallery takes 30 per cent off Pop after Pop until 30 November

The Australian Open's early-bird ground passes close at 12:59pm the same day — and marathon registration shuts tonight at 11:59.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

31 OCT ★ **BYD Singapore International Marathon · entries close**
RACE 4–6 DEC · **10KM, 5KM AND KIDS DASH REGISTRATION SHUTS 11:59PM TONIGHT** · ENTRY FEES UNPUBLISHED

13–22 Nov **Singapore Writers Festival 2026 · "Hidden in Plain Sight"**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · FESTIVAL PASS S$30, YOUTH S$15 · **EARLY BIRD EXPIRED 18 OCT**

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts, 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · FROM S$29 · **SIX FREE STRANDS**, INCLUDING A CHILDREN'S SENSORY STORYTELLING WORKSHOP

25 NOV **Guns N' Roses**
NATIONAL STADIUM · DOORS 5PM · TICKETMASTER ONLY · **GENERAL SALE OPENED 20 MAR; REMAINING STOCK NOT STATED**

3–6 Dec **Voices · A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE AND THE NEW VOICES LOUNGE · **EVERY EVENT FREE** · DROP-IN CRAFT POP-UP ALL FOUR DAYS

11 DEC ★ **Pop after Pop: Art around Us**
NATIONAL GALLERY, TO 4 APR 2027 · FROM S$15, UNDER-6S FREE, S$5 OFF AGES 7–12 · **30% OFF UNTIL 30 NOV** · TIMED ENTRY, NO RE-ENTRY

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ **Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC** · SEAT PRICES NOT PUBLISHED

11–31 Jan ★ **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · GROUND PASSES FROM A$49 · **OPENING WEEK: KIDS A$5, FREE MON 11 JAN · EARLY BIRD ENDS 12:59PM 30 NOV**

31 OCT **Mariko Mori · *All That Shines* opens**
MORI ART MUSEUM, TOKYO, TO 28 MAR 2027 · ¥2,800 WEEKDAY, **FREE TO JUNIOR HIGH AND UNDER · WAVE UFO SLOTS LIMITED**

28 Nov–5 May **Niseko Tokyu Grand HIRAFU · season opens**
TENTATIVE, THE RESORT'S OWN WORD · GONDOLA AND RESTAURANT OPEN 28 NOV REGARDLESS OF SNOW · NIGHT SKIING FROM 12 DEC

17 Oct–31 May **Nabana no Sato · Winter Illumination**
NAGASHIMA, MIE · **CLOSED 6–7 JAN · NO BUS FROM KUWANA STATION DURING THE ILLUMINATION** · PRICE NOT ON THE PAGE

30–31 Jan **HSBC SVNS Singapore 2027**
DATES ONLY — **NO VENUE, NO PRICES AND NO ON-SALE DATE PUBLISHED**. AN ANNOUNCEMENT, NOT YET A BOOKING

PLANNING NOTES · ONE TONIGHT, TWO ON THE THIRTIETH

Tonight, 11:59pm, closes the 10KM, 5KM and Kids Dash at the December marathon — and note the race has been **renamed**: it is no longer the Standard Chartered Singapore Marathon, which now sponsors the 10KM category only. **30 November** carries two unrelated deadlines on two continents: the National Gallery's 30 per cent discount applies automatically at checkout until then, and the Australian Open's early-bird ground passes close at **12:59pm**. **5 December** opens the January sumo.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT SOLD OUT, AND WHAT THIS PAGE COULD NOT CHECK

The November Kyushu sumo tournament is sold out on every single day, and the association's own ticket partner adds that "there will be no tickets sold on the day". That is the only confirmed sell-out in this set. The Australian Open has **capped daily ground-pass numbers for the first time**, so turning up is no longer a plan. And **Christmas Wonderland 2026 has not been announced** — the event's own site still shows 2025 and the words "the magic's just getting started", so this page prints no dates for it, and grades its own failed prediction on p2. **Four Sands Theatre productions and four stadium concerts are absent here because no primary source could be reached.**[2]

SOURCES 1 Each event re-verified at a primary source this week: the organiser's own site for the marathon and its 11:59pm cut-off; the venue's own event page for Guns N' Roses; Esplanade's own festival pages for Kalaa Utsavam, Voices and the Mosaic series; the festival's own site for the Writers Festival; the National Gallery's own exhibition and festival pages, whose dates are also set into the official artwork; the Mori Art Museum's own page for prices, timed entry and the Wave UFO warning; the resort's own winter page for Niseko; the operator's own page for Nabana no Sato; Melbourne Park's own guide, updated 8 October, for the Australian Open. 2 The Japan Sumo Association's own English site and its official ticket partner for the sell-out and the January on-sale date; christmaswonderland.sg, read 30 October. **Marina Bay Sands, Ticketmaster Singapore, the Sports Hub, the Asian Civilisations Museum and teamLab all refused this desk, which is why their events do not appear above rather than appearing unverified.**

THE TABLE · A PERSIAN ROOM ON DEMPSEY

Shirazi opened on Dempsey Road in September and the reviews arrived in late October

Chef Mohammad Hosseini, who grew up in Zanjan, imports his spices from Iran; a grilled platter for two is S$120, and Chope holds four reviews.

Shirazi soft-opened at **8 Dempsey Road** on **8 September 2026** and the food press caught up with it seven weeks later — which is the most interesting thing about it. Chef **Mohammad Hosseini**, who grew up in **Zanjan**, runs it with Chef Ying; the two have cooked together for about two decades, selected spices come directly from Iran, and the room is hung with gilt-framed Persian miniatures under a crystal chandelier. It is the only semi-fine-dining Persian opening in Singapore this year.[1]

The carte reads straightforwardly: cold mezze **S$42**, hot mezze **S$45**, lamb koobideh **S$42**, jujeh kebab **S$42**, ghormeh sabzi **S$35**, and a grilled platter at **S$120 for two** or **S$210 for four**. Free-flow Middle Eastern tea is **S$9.90** a head. The dish to order is the faloodeh — rose-scented vermicelli with saffron ice cream, from a recipe the coverage traces to around 400 BC.[1]

Too new to call, and this page will say so. Chope shows a perfect five from **four reviews, only two carrying any written comment**. One line that has surfaced is double-edged — the room "pristine, more like a museum than a restaurant" — and **this desk could not read it at source; verify the wording before repeating it.** There is no queue and no waitlist, which is itself the news. Open Tuesday to Sunday, closed Mondays, though the booking platform claims otherwise. **Not halal-certified**: halal-certified meat and poultry, but a separate bar on the premises.[1]

Rawr Cafe opened beneath Wink Hostel at **134 Jalan Besar** on **17 October**, from the team behind the tart brand Wunderfolks. The photograph everyone takes is the **SG Breakfast Latte, S$8** — a foam "fried egg" with a kaya-flavoured yolk and a crunchy kaya-toast soldier. A nasi lemak chicken burger is S$18, laksa cream halibut S$24.[2]

Um Yong Baek has opened a third Singapore outlet at **Suntec City**. The brand began in **Busan** and arrived in Telok Ayer in 2022, so this is expansion, not debut: a pork barbecue set for two is **S$84**, and the dish the write-ups lead on is a whole-crab ramyeon at **S$15**. Use **Promenade** station. **Its opening date is not published anywhere.** And **Nyonya Next Door**, at One Shenton since late July, sells Peranakan sets from **S$8.90** — from the team behind Cherki, which has since closed. A fine-dining kitchen that shut, reborn as a counter.[3]

THE BUZZ · A REVIEW THAT DOES NOT GUSH

Eatbook visited Rawr two days after it opened and filed something refreshingly qualified: worth a visit **"if you love cutesy cafés"** — a recommendation on looks, not cooking. The praise went to the breakfast latte and the nasi lemak burger's "bold umami from ikan bilis and sambal". The criticisms are the useful part: the soft shell crab chilli pasta's sauce "tasted more like regular red pasta sauce than chilli crab", and the prawn paste chicken arrived **"pinker than expected"** and "could have been cooked longer". A two-day-old kitchen still finding itself.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO THOUSAND FOUR HUNDRED AND THIRTY-ONE

In the first ten months of 2025, **2,431 Singapore food establishments closed. 63 per cent had been open five years or less — and 82 per cent of those had never once reported a profit** in their annual tax declarations. In the same period **3,357 new outlets opened**. The figures are the Deputy Prime Minister's. Terence Yow of Singapore Tenants United for Fairness: "Within our community, a majority of tenants have reported increases (in) rentals (of) between 20-49%." **This page prints no annual total for 2025, because the published counts genuinely disagree on the counting base — and there is no official churn rate at all, whatever anyone tells you.**[4]

SOURCES 1 HungryGoWhere, 29 October 2026, and the venue's own Chope listing for the address, hours and review count, both read at source; **the one reviewer line quoted is flagged in the text as unread at source because the publisher returned HTTP 403**. 2 Eatbook's review of 19 October 2026 and HungryGoWhere of 30 October; the two differ on opening hours, and the article's own text carries a year typo its dateline corrects. 3 HungryGoWhere, 30 October 2026 and 31 July 2026 respectively, with the Suntec opening date flagged as unpublished. 4 Figures given by the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Trade and Industry, reported via *The Business Times*; the tenants' quotation via CNA. 5 Opening date confirmed across four independent listings placing it in May 2025. **No Reddit or Burpple sentiment appears on this page: this desk searched for threads on all four venues and found none, and would rather print the absence than invent a consensus.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · MALAYSIA'S KREDIT MYKAD

Malaysia loaded nine million people's welfare onto the MyKad chip

The finance ministry reported RM5.2bn of SARA transactions to September 2026 across 14,068 enrolled shops — and the credit expires on 31 December.

In a sundry shop in Kelantan a woman hands across her identity card. The till reads the chip, checks each barcode against a list of about **140,000 approved products** in fifteen categories, deducts only what qualifies, and leaves her to pay for the rest herself. She is not using a bank account, a card or an app. The card is the money.[1]

Malaysia has spent three years building what is probably the largest identity-gated consumption system in Asia outside a ration state, and it has done it in the open. Under **Sumbangan Asas Rahmah** — SARA — welfare is no longer cash. It is credit loaded against the chip of the national identity card, the MyKad, disbursed automatically with no application, spendable only on whitelisted goods, only at enrolled shops, **only by the cardholder in person**, and only before **31 December**, after which the balance evaporates.[1]

The scale is in the finance ministry's own release of **19 October 2026**. To September, nearly **RM11bn** had gone out under SARA and its cash sibling. The sentence that matters reads, in the original: "SARA *bulanan mencatat kadar penggunaan sebanyak* 99.7 *peratus dengan nilai transaksi sebanyak* RM5.2 *bilion*" — a monthly usage rate of **99.7 per cent** on **RM5.2bn** of transactions. Nearly **nine million** people are eligible for the monthly credit; **more than twenty million**, about ninety per cent of recipients, made a purchase under its universal arm.[2]

The card is the money. And at the petrol pump, the card is the price.

The retail network was bought, not borrowed. Partner shops went from about **700** at launch in 2024 to **8,700** in November 2025, **10,447** in January 2026, **13,700** in July and **14,068** by **7 August 2026** — more than six thousand of them small sundry stores. The state supplies the terminals, the installation and the staff training free; the ministry names point-of-sale readiness and internet connectivity as the obstacle, and has targeted ten thousand more small retailers.[3]

Then, in September 2025, the same card became a price. **BUDI95** lets a citizen buy petrol at **RM1.99 a litre** while the unsubsidised pump price stood at **RM3.92** — a citizens-only discount of about **49 per cent** on the identical fuel from the identical nozzle. By **11 February 2026**, more than **14.6 million people** had used it, averaging **3.1 million transactions a day**.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LAUNCH LOOKED LIKE

When a universal RM100 credit was loaded onto the cards of about **22 million adults** in September 2025, the system had to be scaled from five thousand to **fifteen thousand queries a minute**. **2.9 million people spent it within three days**, RM192.4m of it; day three alone carried **1.1 million transactions**, nearly four times the previous peak. By day six, **8.3 million users had spent RM536.9m**; by the end of the first week, **RM642m** across more than 7,300 outlets.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · IT PREDICTED ITSELF

Derek Kok Qi Ren of the Jeffrey Cheah Institute at Sunway University argued in **July 2023**, before SARA scaled, that restricting aid is a political choice dressed as a prudential one: cash is fungible, households know their own needs, and restriction imposes bespoke infrastructure costs — he noted the 2019 targeted petrol system alone cost **RM25.03m** — while producing predictable resale. He cited students reselling book vouchers and young Malaysians converting e-wallet credit, in some cases paying scammers to do it. **He described the secondary market two years before it was reported.**[6]

45×

THE GROWTH IN MONTHLY RECIPIENTS IN THREE YEARS. SARA BEGAN IN 2023 COVERING 200,000 HARDCORE-POOR HOUSEHOLDS AT RM100 A MONTH ACROSS TEN CATEGORIES[6]

SOURCES 1 The official SARA 2026 frequently-asked-questions document, issued 9 February 2026 by the Inland Revenue Board, read in full after extracting the text — the source of the fifteen categories, the cardholder-only rule and the 31 December expiry. 2 The Ministry of Finance's own statement of 19 October 2026, read at source; the Malay sentence is quoted as published. 3 The ministry's own releases of 3 November 2025 and 27 July 2026 and its reply to a senator; the August figure via a Malaysian personal-finance title; the free-terminal and training commitments from national press reporting of 18 May 2026. 4 The ministry's own BUDI95 release of February 2026; the unsubsidised pump price as reported in May 2026. **The monthly fuel quota is given variously as 200 and 300 litres across sources and is therefore not printed here.** 5 National press reporting of 3 September 2025 and the week that followed. 6 Derek Kok Qi Ren, "Cash is Better Than Cashless", Jeffrey Cheah Institute on Southeast Asia, Sunway University, 19 July 2023, read at source.

There is an exchange rate. In a column published in **Sinar Harian** on **5 September 2025**, a writer bylined Merak Jalanan reported a reporter's check among sundry-shop owners in **Kelantan** who were buying SARA credit back for cash. The sentence, as printed: "*Syaratnya kenalah bayar caj* RM20. *Maknanya penerima* SARA *dapat* RM80, *bakinya peniaga sapu.*" The condition is that you pay a charge of twenty ringgit. Meaning the SARA recipient gets eighty, and the trader sweeps the rest.[1]

RM80 for RM100. A twenty per cent haircut, charged for the single service the state has engineered out of the system: turning restricted money back into money. The columnist estimated a shopkeeper doing this for a hundred customers clears RM2,000 with no capital outlay, and wanted traders' licences revoked and recipients blacklisted.[1]

Treat that figure carefully, because this magazine does. It is **one columnist's account of one reporter's survey in one state**, and no arrest, prosecution or enforcement figure for SARA credit conversion could be found anywhere. It is not a national rate. What it is, is the price of a service that should not exist — and it is exactly the price theory predicts, because non-fungible money that expires always finds a discount.[1]

Non-fungible money that expires always finds a discount.

Malaysia has run this experiment before and watched the same thing happen. Students holding **RM250 book vouchers** under the 1Malaysia scheme sold them to bookshop operators for about **RM220** — a thirty-ringgit fee for the same conversion. The Sinar Harian column invokes that precedent itself. In 2023, young Malaysians given **RM200** of e-wallet credit tried to convert it too, some of them paying scammers for the privilege.[2]

The state's answer to leakage has not been redesign. It has been criminal liability. Using another person's MyKad, or their details, to obtain subsidised petrol is prosecutable under **Regulation 25 of the National Registration Regulations 1990**: a fine of up to **RM20,000**, up to **three years' imprisonment**, or both. The finance ministry has ordered petrol companies to ban manual transactions without definitive card verification, to investigate flagged stations and to display the procedure at the counter.[3]

Which is the moment to state what has actually happened here. Lending your identity to a neighbour so he can buy cheaper fuel is now a three-year offence. Not fraud against a bank, not impersonation for gain — sharing a card at a pump. **When identity becomes the price mechanism, identity theft becomes a pricing crime**, and the state must police a boundary it drew through the middle of ordinary reciprocity.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT IN MALAYSIA

It is being had in public, in the press and the think tanks rather than on the platforms. **Dr Mohamad Idham Md Razak**, an economist at UiTM, warns that the budget's tilt from cash towards credit narrows household spending flexibility, and that narrowly targeted schemes breed feelings of unfairness and exclusion; he holds that cash offers more flexibility and more dignity. Shoppers quoted in the national press in May 2026 wanted the *smallest* neighbourhood shops enrolled so they need not travel to a supermarket to spend their credit on basics — a complaint about the geography of the whitelist, not about the whitelist. And the operator's own merchant notice warns traders not to pay any "registration deposit" to people claiming to enrol them: a fraud economy has formed around access to the rail itself.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THIS IS FOOD STAMPS WITH A CHIP

The honest counter to everything argued here: the United States ran electronic benefit transfer for decades, and nobody calls Ohio a ration state. A **99.7 per cent** usage rate suggests the money reaches people and gets used. The only documented cash-out evidence is one reporter's survey in one state. The government's own defence — that card verification keeps subsidy with citizens, and that identity-linked diesel reform alone is projected to save up to **RM2bn a year** — is not obviously wrong. **An efficiently targeted transfer is not a new political form, and calling it one may be a category error.** The strongest version of this essay's argument has to survive that sentence.[5]

RM25.03m

WHAT MALAYSIA'S 2019 TARGETED PETROL SUBSIDY SYSTEM COST TO BUILD — THE FIGURE KOK CITED WHEN ARGUING THAT RESTRICTION HAS AN INFRASTRUCTURE BILL CASH DOES NOT[2]

SOURCES 1 The Sinar Harian column of 5 September 2025, read at source; the Malay sentence is quoted exactly as published and translated here. **It remains single-sourced and is flagged as such in the text.** 2 The same column and Derek Kok's 2023 paper, both of which cite the book-voucher precedent; the two differ on its year. 3 Reporting of 29 May 2026 on the ministry's instruction to fuel retailers and the statutory penalty under the 1990 regulations. 4 Dr Mohamad Idham Md Razak via a national daily; shoppers quoted in national press reporting of 18 May 2026; the operator's own merchant notice. 5 The diesel saving as reported on 25 June 2026; the usage rate from the finance ministry's own release. **Reddit and the Malaysian social platforms were unreachable from this desk, so there is no social-media sentiment anywhere in this essay: every voice is a named person in the press, an academic paper or an official document.**

What Malaysia has built is not a generous welfare state or a mean one. It is a different machine, and three things follow from it that are worth saying plainly.

First, the single national price is gone. At a forecourt in Johor the same litre from the same nozzle costs **RM1.99 or RM3.92** depending on the chip in your pocket. Economists have modelled price discrimination for a century; what is new is that the discriminating variable is citizenship, verified at the till, enforced by criminal law. A price is no longer a property of a good. It is a property of the buyer.

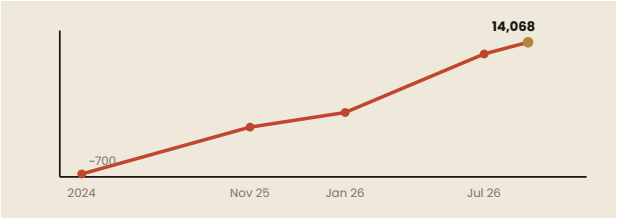
Second, welfare has become demand management. Credit that cannot be saved, cannot be invested, cannot be lent and must be spent inside the calendar year on a list of approved goods is not income support in the ordinary sense. It is a transfer engineered to pass straight through the household and into the till of an enrolled shop. The **99.7 per cent** usage rate is not evidence that the design is working for recipients. It is evidence that the design is working as designed, because expiring money has nowhere else to go.[1]

A price is no longer a property of a good. It is a property of the buyer.

Third, the state has quietly bought the retail sector it needed. Fourteen thousand shops, more than six thousand of them small and independent, now take their terminals, their training and a rising share of their footfall from Putrajaya — which in exchange acquires shelf-level visibility into what nine million poor Malaysians eat. The finance ministry has said it is the sole custodian of recipients' personal data and that a firewall separates it from merchants' transaction records. That is a reassurance about handling. It is not a denial that the data exists.[2]

And the rail keeps swallowing things. Groceries in 2023; petrol in September 2025; a universal credit the same month; diesel in 2026; cooking oil under study; and from the budget tabled on **9 October 2026**, fresh and wet goods at **216** farmers' markets, with the envelope raised to **RM16bn** and a new payment reaching about **13 million** adults who are not poor at all — explicitly including middle-income households.[3]

That last detail is the one to watch, because it changes what the system is for. A rail built to target the poorest is now being pointed at the middle. A government that can switch twenty-two million people's consumption on and off by category and by calendar holds an instrument no Malaysian government has held before, and instruments get used.



Shops enrolled to accept the credit, 2024 to 7 August 2026. A *Meridian* original, drawn from the finance ministry's own dated releases.[4]

The reason this matters beyond Malaysia is that the hard part is no longer the hard part. Identity-gated consumption needs a universal biometric or chip identity card, near-universal retail terminals and a state willing to legislate. The Philippines and Pakistan both have the first two. What Malaysia has supplied is the third, and the demonstration that it works: ninety-nine point seven per cent, in the open, on a national budget line, with the middle class next.

The sceptic's sentence from the facing page stands, and should. This may be food stamps with a chip. But food stamps did not set the price of petrol, did not expire in December, did not make lending your card a three-year offence, and were not pointed at the middle class in their fourth year. Somewhere in that list, a welfare programme became something else, and the exchange rate in a Kelantan shop — **eighty for a hundred** — is the market's own estimate of the difference.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Finance's own statement of 19 October 2026. 2 The ministry's statement of September 2025 on data custody, in which it also denied making any payment to the scheme's operating foundation. 3 The Budget 2027 measures as tabled on 9 October 2026 and reported by a Malaysian personal-finance title. 4 Figures as in the dated ministry releases cited on p25; the chart is this magazine's own drawing of them. 5 The Sinar Harian column of 5 September 2025, single-sourced as flagged on p26. **Two analogies were considered for this essay and dropped because they could not be verified at source in the time available: American food-stamp trafficking rates before and after electronification, and Iran's identity-linked petrol card of 2007. The two Malaysian precedents used instead are documented in the sources above.**

THE LAST WORD

The number on the box

A loudspeaker's sensitivity is printed on its specification sheet. Buchardt says eighty-seven decibels and measures eighty-four point seven; Børresen says eighty-eight and measures eighty-five point nine. Both wrong by about two and a third, both wrong in the same direction — which is roughly a doubling of the amplifier you will need to buy (p6).

The week kept doing this. Three central banks held their headline rate in seventy-two hours and every dissenting vote was to raise — while the Federal Reserve instructed its own desk to buy Treasury bills and the Bank of Japan more than doubled the rate at which it sells equities back into the market. The price of money was restrictive. The quantity was not (p14). A film opened at ninety-nine per cent from a hundred and fifty-four critics and four thousand dollars a screen (p11). A hobbyist's six-dollar bottle of Hedione costs two hundred and eighty to land in Singapore (p16), and the balance that reads to a thousandth of a gram is specified by its own maker to two thousandths. A study put each extra unit of fitness at sixteen per cent off the risk of death, and raised its own model's discrimination by two one-hundredths (p18).

And in Malaysia the thing is no longer a figure of speech. At a forecourt in Johor the same litre costs one ringgit ninety-nine or three ringgit ninety-two, and which one you pay is decided by the chip in your identity card. A price has stopped being a property of the good and become a property of the buyer — and in a shop in Kelantan someone will convert the difference back into money for a twenty per cent fee (p25). Eighty for a hundred: the market's own estimate of what the label costs.

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SOURCES **A note on method.** This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the Federal Reserve's own statement and the implementation note issued beside it; the Bank of Japan's own Statement on Monetary Policy, extracted from its published PDF; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves; Malaysia's finance ministry and its tax authority's own scheme documents; a Luang Prabang tourism authority's own ticket pages; a Singapore ministry's own labour release and two more ministries' joint statements; eight journal papers at their journals or at PubMed Central; two public code repositories' own issues and pull requests; manufacturers' and dealers' own storefronts in six currencies; and venue, promoter or museum pages for every dated event on p23. **Figures that are this magazine's own arithmetic — the ten-year breakeven and the 2s10s spread on p14, the capital-spending implication on p7, the shop-count chart on p27 — say so where they appear.** Where a host refused us — **Reddit for the sixteenth issue running, and so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; Wikimedia for the second; OpenAI's own announcement page, Audio-Technica, Luxman, Stereophile, Audiogon, diyAudio, Basenotes, the Fragrantica forums, Marina Bay Sands, Ticketmaster Singapore, UNESCO, Singapore's energy authority, Hong Kong's government portals, the Spanish transport ministry, Billboard and six Luang Prabang hotels** — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. **A correction to No. 148 runs on p11. Every photograph in this issue was downloaded and looked at before it was captioned.**